

SBC SUN BELT PREVIEW



PREDICTED ORDER OF FINISH

EAST

	1	JAMES MADISON DUKES
	2	OLD DOMINION MONARCHS
	3	MARSHALL THUNDERING HERD
	4	GEORGIA SOUTHERN EAGLES
	5	APPALACHIAN STATE MOUNTAINEERS
	6	COASTAL CAROLINA CHANTICLEERS
	7	GEORGIA STATE PANTHERS

WEST

	1	TROY TROJANS
	2	ARKANSAS STATE RED WOLVES
	3	LOUISIANA TECH BULLDOGS
	4	LOUISIANA RAGIN' CAJUNS
	5	SOUTH ALABAMA JAGUARS
	6	SOUTHERN MISS GOLDEN EAGLES
	7	ULM WARHAWKS

SUN BELT CHAMPIONSHIP

TROY OVER JAMES MADISON



JOIN COLLEGE FOOTBALL EXPERT STEVEN LASSAN AT ATHLONSPORTS.COM FOR A LOOK AT SECOND- AND THIRD-TEAM SELECTIONS

ALL-SUN BELT TEAM

FIRST-TEAM OFFENSE

QB	GOOSE CROWDER	Troy
RB	DEVIN ROCHE	Old Dominion
RB	JAQUARI LEWIS	Appalachian State
AP	DEVIN SPENCER	Arkansas State
WR	CHAUNCY COBB	Arkansas State
WR	JOSH DALLAS	Georgia Southern
WR	SHELTON SAMPSON JR.	Louisiana
TE	TOBY PAYNE	Marshall
C	ZACH GREENBERG	James Madison
OL	JALEN SLAPPY	Marshall
OL	TRISTIAN SMITH	Arkansas State
OL	KADEN MOREAU	Louisiana
OL	JORDON JONES	Troy

FIRST-TEAM DEFENSE

DL	DONNIE SMITH	Troy
DL	AMAR THOMAS	James Madison
DL	CHRIS FORBES	Old Dominion
LB	KOLBE FIELDS	Louisiana Tech
LB	MJ STROUD	Georgia Southern
LB	COLTON PHARES	Appalachian State
LB	NOAH FLEMMINGS	ULM
LB	ANTHONY BYNUM	Georgia Southern
CB	CHANCE GAMBLE	Georgia Southern
CB	BRENT GORDON JR.	Louisiana
S	DAYTONE SMITH	Marshall
S	MARIO EASTERLY	Old Dominion

FIRST-TEAM SPECIALISTS

K	CLUNE VAN ANDEL	Arkansas State
P	EVAN CRENSHAW	Troy
KR	CHAUNCY COBB	Arkansas State
PR	DEVIN ROCHE	Old Dominion

BOWL PROJECTIONS

Salute to Veterans: Georgia Southern vs. Delaware

68 Ventures: Arkansas State vs. Jacksonville State

Xbox: Old Dominion vs. Utah State

Myrtle Beach: Marshall vs. Liberty

Boca Raton: Troy vs. Miami (Ohio)

New Orleans: James Madison vs. WKU

Frisco: Louisiana Tech vs. Central Michigan

COORDINATOR CAROUSEL

APPALACHIAN STATE

Offense: New: Mike Anthony
Old: Dowell Loggains

ARKANSAS STATE

Offense: New: Garrett Altman
Old: Keith Heckendorf

COASTAL CAROLINA

Offense: New: Nick Petrino
Old: Drew Hollingshead
Defense: New: L.D. Scott
Old: Jeremiah Johnson

GEORGIA SOUTHERN

Defense: New: Mike Mutz
Old: Brandon Bailey

GEORGIA STATE

Defense: New: Cam Clark, John Haneline; Old: Travis Pearson

JAMES MADISON

Offense: New: Cam Aiken
Old: Dean Kennedy
Defense: New: Robert Bala, Josh Linam
Old: Colin Hitschler

LOUISIANA TECH

Offense: New: Nathan Young
Old: Tony Franklin

MARSHALL

Defense: New: Brad Lambert
Old: Shannon Morrison

OLD DOMINION

Offense: New: Kody Cook
Old: Kevin Decker

SOUTH ALABAMA

Offense: New: Major Applewhite
Old: Paul Petrino
Defense: New: Todd Orlando, Jason Washington; Old: Will Windham

SOUTHERN MISS

Offense: New: Kyle Cefalo
Old: Blake Anderson
Defense: New: Joe Bolden
Old: Jason Semore

TROY

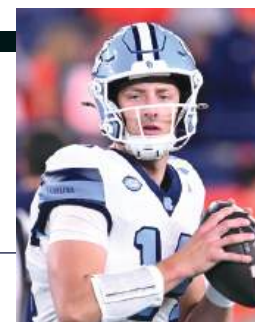
Offense: New: Adam Austin
Old: Sean Reagan

ULM

Offense: New: Jesse Montalto
Old: Bryant Vincent
Defense: New: Troy Reffett
Old: Earnest Hill

TOP 10 RECRUITS

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	RATING	NAT. RANK
1. Jordan Harris	EDGE	Appalachian State	★★★	434
2. Jamel Howse	TE	Appalachian State	★★★	507
3. Maxwell Robinson	IOL	Georgia State	★★★	552
4. Xavier McDonald	WR	James Madison	★★★	566
5. Micah Williams	S	App State	★★★	747



GOOSE CROWDER, TROY
MAX JOHNSON, GEORGIA SOUTHERN

TOP TRANSFERS

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	FORMER SCHOOL
1. Max Johnson	QB	Georgia Southern	North Carolina
He's on school No. 4 and season No. 7 with 6,000-plus yards of total offense to his name.			
2. Trey Owens	QB	Arkansas State	Texas
Owens is a prolific passer and blue-chip talent who's replacing a three-year starter.			
3. Malachi Singleton	QB	Appalachian State	Purdue
The Mountaineers are betting on Singleton's talent and mobility.			
4. Rashon Myles Jr.	LB	Georgia Southern	Abilene Christian
Myles earned FCS All-America honors, racking up 100-plus tackles in the process.			
5. Jeremiah Harrison	WR	James Madison	ETSU
Harrison quickly made a name for himself in the FCS with his field-stretching abilities.			
6. Donovan Grayson	DL	Coastal Carolina	Samford
Grayson lived in the backfield in the FCS, earning All-SoCon honors and FBS interest.			
7. Xavier Bausley	OL	Marshall	West Virginia
Bausley brings size and starting experience to anchor the Thundering Herd's O-line.			
8. Five Hamilton	DB	Arkansas State	Kennesaw State
A key contributor for the CUSA champs, Hamilton adds secondary stability.			
9. Arrington Maiden	QB	James Madison	Memphis
Maiden has big shoes to fill for the Dukes, but he brings a rocket arm to the table.			
10. Donald Chaney Jr.	RB	ULM	Charlotte
Seventh-year senior with P4 experience and 1,000-plus career yards from scrimmage.			

RECRUITING RANKINGS BY SCHOOL

1. Appalachian State (62)	6. Georgia Southern (90)
2. South Alabama (75)	7. Arkansas State (92)
3. James Madison (81)	8. Louisiana (95)
4. Troy (83)	9. Louisiana Tech (96)
5. Old Dominion (89)	10. Georgia State (98)

11. Southern Miss (107)
12. Coastal Carolina (112)
13. Marshall (121)
14. ULM (124)

*Rankings per Rivals;
National ranking in parentheses*

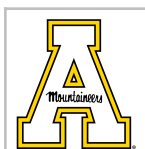
GAMES TO WATCH

Sept. 5 Liberty at James Madison
Sept. 5 Arkansas State at Memphis
Sept. 19 James Madison at San Diego St.
Sept. 19 East Carolina at Old Dominion
Sept. 26 James Madison at Old Dominion
Oct. 10 Louisiana at Louisiana Tech

Oct. 15 Ga. Southern at Old Dominion
Oct. 17 Arkansas State at Southern Miss
Oct. 17 Troy at Louisiana
Oct. 29 Troy at James Madison
Nov. 21 Georgia Southern at Troy
Nov. 28 Louisiana Tech at Ga. Southern

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	RATING	NAT. RANK
6. Kamden Jennings	CB	James Madison	★★★	777
7. Chauncey Davis Jr.	CB	Southern Miss	★★★	814
8. Kamauri Austin	WR	Appalachian State	★★★	834
9. Manny Lewis	DL	Appalachian State	★★★	848
10. Keivay Foster	S	Troy	★★★	863

Rankings per Rivals industry ranking.



APPALACHIAN STATE MOUNTAINEERS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 117 | SUN BELT EAST PREDICTION: 5 | 2025 RECORD: 5-8, 2-6 SBC

OFFENSE The Mountaineers finished in the bottom third of the Sun Belt offensively last season, averaging only 24.2 points per game while turning the ball over 22 times, including 15 interceptions. To improve production, head coach Dowell Loggains will turn to a new starting quarterback via the transfer portal. App State added Malachi Singleton, Henry Hasselbeck and Tommy Ulatowski to the roster, with Singleton and Hasselbeck battling for the starting job. Singleton previously played at Arkansas and Purdue, making 11 appearances for the Boilermakers last season. The redshirt junior's dual-threat ability should boost App State's offense.

The running game looks good with Jaquari Lewis back for his sophomore season after rushing for 618 yards and six touchdowns in 2025.

Wide receivers Sam Mbake and Alex Sanchez need to increase their production after combining for 33 catches a year ago. Portal additions Chris Lofton and Dazmin James will help in major ways. Lofton led the FCS Big South with 934 receiving yards at Gardner-Webb last season.

The offensive line needs Tyriq Poindexter and Trent Ramsey to return to starting form after injuries cut their seasons short a year ago.

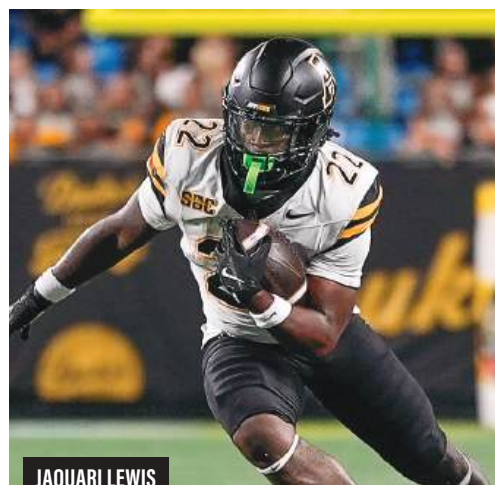
DEFENSE After surrendering 416.6 yards per game, App State seeks more consistency. Productive years from edge rushers Aiden Benton and Caleb Sandstrom are essential. The Mountaineers are also counting on linebacker Colton Phares, the team leader with 101 tackles and three interceptions last season. He'll need help in the middle from portal additions Alex Mitchell (Middle Tennessee) and Carson Sloan (FCS Samford).

The secondary needs a big season from cornerback Juan Berchal, who gained valuable experience as a freshman. Junior Ja'Den McBurrows can be a playmaker if he is fully healed from the injury that cost him most of last season. A host of transfers, including former ACC players Joe Reddish (Virginia Tech) and Khalil Conley (North Carolina), will be pivotal to App State's fortunes here.

SPECIALISTS In 2024, James London kicked six field goals of 50 yards or more for FCS Murray State and was a third-team FCS All-American. He was at Pitt prior to last season but left the team in August after losing a kicking competition. Punting is questionable as sophomore Jaxson Dunn, an Arkansas State transfer, has never played at the college level.

FINAL ANALYSIS A renowned giant-killer (hello, Michigan), App State started its FBS existence in 2014 and reeled off eight consecutive winning seasons. But the Mountaineers have had only one winning season in the past four. To reverse the slide, App State needs instant impact from the transfer additions and a strong return from injuries for several players.

2025 RESULTS (5-8, 2-6 SBC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*					
Aug. 29	at Charlotte	W	34-11	Sept. 5	Maine	1. Jordan Harris, EDGE	★★★★				
Sept. 6	Lindenwood	W	20-13	Sept. 12	at East Carolina	2. Micah Williams, S	★★★				
Sept. 13	at Southern Miss	L	22-38	Sept. 19	Charlotte	3. Caden Muskus, OT	★★★				
Sept. 27	at Boise State	L	14-47	Sept. 26	at NC State	4. Jamel Howse, TE	★★★				
Oct. 4	Oregon State	W	27-23	Oct. 10	Old Dominion	5. Kamauri Austin, WR	★★★				
Oct. 11	at Georgia State	W	41-20	Oct. 16	at Coastal Carolina	6. Manny Lewis, DL	★★★				
Oct. 18	Coastal Carolina	L	37-45	Oct. 22	James Madison	7. Bronzden Chaffin, QB	★★★				
Oct. 25	at Old Dominion	L	21-24	Oct. 31	at Georgia Southern	8. Nate Branch, WR	★★★				
Nov. 6	Georgia Southern	L	23-25	Nov. 7	Georgia State	9. Scotland Dover, IOL	★★★				
Nov. 15	at James Madison	L	10-58	Nov. 14	at Marshall	10. Eisa Evans, OT	★★★				
Nov. 22	Marshall	W	26-24	Nov. 21	ULM		★★★				
Nov. 29	Arkansas State	L	29-30	Nov. 28	at South Alabama						
Dec. 29	vs. Georgia Southern #L		10-29								
#Birmingham Bowl				*Per Rivals							
TEAM INFORMATION											
Head Coach: Dowell Loggains • Record at School: 5-8 (1 year)											
Career Record: 5-8 (1 year) • Offensive Coordinator: Mike Anthony											
Defensive Coordinator: DJ Smith • Location: Boone, N.C.											
Stadium: Kidd Brewer Stadium (30,000)											



JAQUARI LEWIS

SCOUTING THE MOUNTAINEERS

"I think football purists want them to be good, and they want them to be what App State is known to be. In recent history, I don't know that the wins and expectations have met. It's about coming to grips with this new world of college football, where you almost start with an entirely new team. ... The transition [last year] of a new head coach, trying to understand the Sun Belt, which is a very tough conference, you're trying to get the pieces in place. I know they had some first-year growing pains. They got banged up in a few spots; they lost a quarterback like [UCLA/Tennessee transfer] Joey Aguilar. That's not easy. But I think there's enough pride with the people in those buildings that they should be able to turn it around this year."

—An opposing Sun Belt assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (2)

WR	6	Chris Lofton* (Jr.)	89	Zach Taylor* (So.)
WR	9	Dazmin James* (Jr.)	80	Doopah Coleman (So.)
WR	12	Sam Mbake (Sr.)	16	Alex Sanchez (So.)
LT	65	Mac Walters* (Sr.)	75	Greydon Grimes (So.)
LG	78	Tyriq Poindexter (Sr.)	70	Big Al Oliver (Fr.)
C	52	CAYDEN SWEATT (JR.)	56	Jayden Thomas (So.)
RG	67	TRENT RAMSEY (SR.)	68	Lance Williams (Jr.)
RT	74	Kamron Burris* (Jr.)	57	Devon Manuel* (Sr.)
TE	7	Darrin Fugitt* (Sr.)	87	Dillon Galloway (So.)
QB	3	Malachi Singleton* (Jr.)	8	Henry Hasselbeck* (So.)
RB	5	Jaquari Lewis (So.)	20	J'Marion Burnette* (Jr.)

DEFENSE (2)

EDGE	41	Caleb Sandstrom (Jr.)	94	Caleb Pitts (So.)
DT	50	Jehchys Brown* (Jr.)	45	Nick Campbell (Sr.)
DT	99	Aaron Clark* (So.)	95	Ki'Shawn Harvey* (Jr.)
DE	33	AIDEN BENTON (JR.)	44	Manny Lewis (Fr.)
LB	10	COLTON PHARES (JR.)	5	Carson Sloan* (Jr.)
LB	15	Alex Mitchell* (Sr.)	13	Keshawn Thomas* (Sr.)
CB	0	Juan Berchal (So.)	6	Khalil Conley* (So.)
CB	24	Josh Williams (Jr.)	21	Joe Reddish* (Jr.)
STAR	1	Ja'Den McBurrows (Jr.)	4	Jakob Gude* (So.)
SS	12	Cary Grant* (Sr.)	25	Kaleb Purdy* (Sr.)
FS	27	Cam Fleming (Jr.)	7	Devin Henderson* (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	83	James London* (Jr.)	KR	13	Jackson Grier (Jr.)
P	40	Jaxson Dunn* (So.)	PR	13	Jackson Grier (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



ROBBY WASHINGTON

SCOUTING THE CHANTICLEERS

"[New head coach Ryan Beard] definitely has everyone's attention after the job he did at Missouri State. I don't know that we as a program go, 'Hey, we've gotta look out for Coastal.' That's not how we operate, but seeing some crossover film of what [Beard's Missouri State team] did last year, they did everything well. It almost seemed like our guys got a sense of comfort watching what Missouri State did well [to our mutual opponent] on film. ... He's done a nice job. He's earned this opportunity. The length of time that it took him to flip Missouri State, that's definitely a testament to his ability to coach, call plays, get guys motivated and get guys ready to play."

— An opposing Sun Belt assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (1)

WR	1	Robby Washington (Jr.)	6	Krosse Johnson* (So.)
WR	18	Clayton Coppock Jr.* (So.)	14	Colton Hinton (Sr.)
WR	0	Karmello English (Sr.)	3	Tristian Gardner* (So.)
LT	54	Gavin McLaughlin (So.)	70	Daniel Jones (Jr.)
LG	76	Cristian Loaiza* (Sr.)	72	Dominic Rijos (So.)
C	58	Apisa Pomele* (Sr.)	52	Gabe Jones (Fr.)
RG	66	Kain McDonald (So.)	50	Nasir Jones (Fr.)
RT	68	Mason Barton* (Jr.)	56	Tray Franklin (Sr.)
TE	33	ZACH COURTNEY (SR.)	9	Cyrus Ellison* (Sr.)
QB	2	Deuce Bailey* (Fr.)	12	Osiris Lopez (Fr.)
RB	23	Dominic Knicely (So.)	25	Jaden Allen-Hendrix* (So.)

DEFENSE (4)

DE	40	Chandavian Bradley* (Jr.)	52	Ibrahim Diawara (Sr.)
DT	35	Xzavier Booker* (Jr.)	98	Desmond Barnes* (So.)
DT	90	Reggie Jean* (Sr.)	92	Ahmad Poole* (Sr.)
DE	94	Donovan Grayson* (Jr.)	93	Obinna Onwuka (So.)
LB	34	Wyatt Gedeon (Sr.)	4	Marcellius Pulliam* (Jr.)
LB	55	TRAY BROWN (SR.)	39	Jordan Thompson* (Jr.)
HUSKY	19	SE'VON MCDOWELL (JR.)		Jesse Powell II* (Sr.)
CB	2	JA'MARION WAYNE (SR.)	36	Damill Bostic Jr.* (So.)
CB	14	MYLES WOODS (JR.)	8	Gabe White* (Jr.)
S	12	Dre Pinckney (Sr.)	17	Chris Henry (So.)
S	6	Jalen Lee* (Sr.)	25	Brandon Rose (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	30	Nico Cavanillas Alt* (Sr.)	KR	6	Krosse Johnson* (So.)
P	29	Emile Sebaundi (Sr.)	PR	1	Robby Washington (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



COASTAL CAROLINA CHANTICLEERS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 119 | SUN BELT EAST PREDICTION: 6 | 2025 RECORD: 6-7, 5-3 SBC

OFFENSE New head coach Ryan Beard has brought offensive coordinator Nick Petrino with him from Missouri State. Petrino runs a pro-style offense with the quarterback often under center.

No Chanticleers **QB** is returning from 2025. The contestants for the job include redshirt freshman Missouri State transfer Deuce Bailey, Arkansas redshirt sophomore transfer Trever Jackson, junior-college transfer Tre Guerra and freshman Osiris Lopez, the high school touchdown pass record-holder in Massachusetts. All four have run-pass versatility.

Running back Dominic Knicely, wide receiver Robby Washington and tight end Zach Courtney are the most impactful returning skill-position players. Kennesaw State transfer Clayton Coppock Jr. and tight end Cyrus Ellison from FCS South Carolina State figure to be featured targets.

The offensive line features a number of offseason additions and must replace both starting tackles, who left for Power 4 programs.

DEFENSE New defensive coordinator L.D. Scott, who also arrived from Missouri State, believes that his defensive line will be the strength of his base 4-3 unit. Oklahoma State transfer Chandavian Bradley, Samford transfer Donovan Grayson and senior Ibrahim Diawara are expected to pressure the quarterback at defensive end, while largely experienced transfers will man the interior of the line.

Linebackers Tray Brown, Wyatt Gedeon and Se'Von McDowell return, and junior Marcellius Pulliam transferred in from Michigan State.

Cornerbacks Ja'Marion Wayne and Myles Woods return after being among the 2025 stats leaders in the secondary. FCS South Dakota State transfer safety Jalen Lee is a welcome addition.

SPECIALISTS A pair of FCS transfers, Nico Cavanillas Alt* (South Carolina State) and Daniel Porto (Florida A&M), are vying for the placekicking job. Both were 2025 all-conference selections. Punter Emile Sebaundi returns after averaging 42.7 yards per punt with 15 inside the 20 and only four touchbacks. Washington and receivers Colton Hinton and Karmello English are punt return candidates. Arkansas transfer Krosse Johnson, Breyahn Townsend and Knicely have elite speed for kickoff returns.

FINAL ANALYSIS Beard led Missouri State to a 7-5 record in its first season at the FBS level. It's a young staff, as Beard, Petrino and Scott are all in their 30s. Beard has welcomed at least 56 incoming players, including at least 38 from the transfer portal, 13 high school signees and five juco transfers. He also has an entirely new coaching staff, many of them following him from Missouri State. The incoming players and new staff members will largely determine CCU's fate this season.

2025 RESULTS (6-7, 5-3 SBC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*					
Aug. 30	at Virginia	L	7-48	Sept. 5	at West Virginia	1. Zeke Marshall, S	★★★				
Sept. 6	Charleston Southern	W	13-0	Sept. 12	Fordham	2. Osiris Lopez, QB	★★★				
Sept. 13	East Carolina	L	0-38	Sept. 19	at Delaware	3. Michael Knight, CB	★★★				
Sept. 20	at South Alabama	W	38-20	Sept. 24	Liberty	4. Kadarus Hainsworth, WR	★★★				
Oct. 4	at Old Dominion	L	7-47	Oct. 3	Georgia Southern	5. Travis Roman, CB	★★★				
Oct. 11	ULM	W	23-8	Oct. 10	at Marshall	6. Stephan Aristil, OT	★★★				
Oct. 18	at Appalachian State	W	45-37	Oct. 16	Appalachian State	7. Gabe Jones, IOL	★★★				
Oct. 30	Marshall	W	44-27	Oct. 31	at Georgia State	8. Aiden Parker, LB	★★★				
Nov. 8	Georgia State	W	40-27	Nov. 7	Old Dominion	9. Nasir Jones, IOL	★★★				
Nov. 15	at Georgia Southern	L	40-45	Nov. 14	Arkansas State	10. Jayden Johnson, WR	★★★				
Nov. 22	at South Carolina	L	7-51	Nov. 21	at Louisiana						
Nov. 29	James Madison	L	10-59	Nov. 28	at James Madison						
Dec. 30	vs. Louisiana Tech #	L	14-23								
#Independence Bowl				*Per Rivals							
TEAM INFORMATION											
Head Coach: Ryan Beard • Record at School: First Season											
Career Record: 19-16 (3 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Nick Petrino											
Defensive Coordinator: L.D. Scott • Location: Conway, S.C.											
Stadium: Brooks Stadium (21,000)											



GEORGIA SOUTHERN EAGLES

NATIONAL FORECAST: 102 | SUN BELT EAST PREDICTION: 4 | 2025 RECORD: 7-6, 4-4 SBC

OFFENSE Whatever other concerns the Eagles have about their new quarterback, resilience isn't one of them: After six turbulent years at LSU, Texas A&M and North Carolina, 24-year-old journeyman Max Johnson has endured just about every trial big-time college football has to offer. Johnson still has another year to burn, which he opted to spend in his home state. Even if he goes the distance as QB1, there should be plenty of reps reserved for their apparent Weston Bryan, who accounted for six touchdowns on just 49 snaps as a freshman.

The skill positions suffered significant graduation losses. Outgoing running back OJ Arnold left a 1,100-yard hole in the backfield to be filled by a homegrown committee of backs in at least their third year in the program. GSU invested its transfer portal capital on a fleet of Power 4 wideouts who never quite lived up to their recruiting rank at their previous stops. One name locals will recognize is Josh Dallas, a breakout candidate who missed nearly all of 2025 to a hip injury after hauling in a team-high six TD catches in 2024.

DEFENSE First-year coordinator Mike Mutz is charged with reviving a unit that ranked last in the Sun Belt in both total defense and yards per play allowed. The headliner is All-Sun Belt edge rusher MJ Stroud, and Mutz also inherited established players at defensive tackle (Caleb Moore and Latrell Bullard), linebacker (Brandon Tyson) and cornerback (Tracy Hill Jr. and Chance Gamble).

Like Mutz himself, most of the new arrivals come from the FCS ranks, including a handful of transfers he either coached or coached against during a three-year stint at Stephen F. Austin. Safety Aaron Sears was an all-conference pick at SFA, as was linebacker Rashon Myles Jr. at rival Abilene Christian.

SPECIALISTS Placekicker Tripp Bryant was reliable as a freshman, up to a point, connecting on 16-of-16 field-goal attempts from inside 40 yards. Beyond that point, he was just 2-of-5. Senior Alex Smith, a former Australian tennis pro, is back for his fourth year as the primary punter. There is some experience in the return game but not much proven juice.

FINAL ANALYSIS Clay Helton's tenure has been nondescript, yielding a 6-6 regular-season in three of his first four seasons and a 27-25 record overall. The good news in Year 5 is that the defense will almost certainly be improved, if only because there's not much room for it to get much worse. If the Eagles settle on a quarterback and a playmaker or two from the portal haul at wide receiver, a dark-horse run in the Sun Belt East is not out of the question. Otherwise, the outlook is more of the same.

2025 RESULTS (7-6, 4-4 SBC)			2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	at Fresno State	L 14-42	Sept. 5	Charleston South.	1. Ty Cummings, RB	★★★
Sept. 6	at USC	L 20-59	Sept. 12	at Clemson	2. JQ Crosby, TE	★★★
Sept. 13	Jacksonville State	W 41-34	Sept. 19	at Jacksonville St.	3. Jayden Jackson, ATH	★★★
Sept. 20	Maine	W 45-17	Sept. 26	Houston	4. RJ Isaac, CB	★★★
Sept. 27	at James Madison	L 10-35	Oct. 3	at Coastal Carolina	5. Alec Upshaw, DL	★★★
Oct. 9	Southern Miss	L 35-38	Oct. 10	James Madison	6. Max Haertel, S	★★★
Oct. 18	Georgia State	W 41-24	Oct. 15	at Old Dominion	7. Tylin Drakeford, CB	★★★
Oct. 25	at Arkansas State	L 24-34	Oct. 31	Appalachian State	8. Dariyon Gordon, CB	★★★
Nov. 6	at Appalachian State	W 25-23	Nov. 7	Marshall	9. Jaden Johnson, OT	★★★
Nov. 15	Coastal Carolina	W 45-40	Nov. 14	at Georgia State	10. Grady Howell, OT	★★★
Nov. 22	Old Dominion	L 10-45	Nov. 21	at Troy		
Nov. 29	at Marshall	W 24-19	Nov. 28	Louisiana Tech		*Per Rivals
Dec. 29	vs. Appalachian State #	W 29-10				
#Birmingham Bowl			TEAM INFORMATION			
			Head Coach: Clay Helton • Record at School: 27-25 (4 years)			
			Career Record: 73-49 (10+ years) • Offensive Coordinator: Ryan Aplin			
			Defensive Coordinator: Mike Mutz • Location: Statesboro, Ga.			
			Stadium: Allen E. Paulson Stadium (25,000)			



JOSH DALLAS

SCOUTING THE EAGLES

"I would expect to see improvement. I know that we create some issues matchup-wise with our offensive personnel against them, and our scheme just naturally presents challenges for that defense. It was a perfect storm of things. ... They've been able to score points and move the ball. It almost seems like from an outside perspective, their philosophy is just to try and outscore everybody while getting enough stops. As in, can you keep up? It's just what it seems like they do at times. ... I love, love, love [UNC transfer quarterback] Max Johnson. He's awesome. Competitive. Smart. Tough. Built the right way. Loves ball, competes his a— off. He can spin it. He makes really good decisions with the ball."

— An opposing Sun Belt assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (1)

WR	18	Andre Greene Jr.* (Sr.)	88	Alex Taylor* (So.)
WR	21	Ashton Hollins* (Sr.)	89	Noble Johnson* (Jr.)
WR	19	JOSH DALLAS (SR.)	85	Kam Mikell* (So.)
LT	64	Caelan Williams (Sr.)	51	Matthew Williams (Jr.)
LG	56	Mo Clipper Jr.* (Sr.)	72	Josh Raymond* (So.)
C	53	Ty Furnish (Sr.)	55	Ethan Williams (Jr.)
RG	65	Cole Norred* (So.)	75	Kingtriton Samuela (So.)
RT	63	Colin Alexander (So.)	77	Ike Turner (Fr.)
TE	87	River Helms (Sr.)	84	JP Mikhael (Jr.)
QB	7	Max Johnson* (Sr.)	9	Weston Bryan (So.)
RB	6	David Mbadanga (Sr.)	20	Terrance Gibbs (Sr.)

DEFENSE (4)

DE	4	Anthony Bynum* (Jr.)	51	Kebba Secka (Jr.)
NT	57	LATRELL BULLARD (SR.)	90	O'Marion Brown* (Jr.)
DT	93	CALEB MOORE (JR.)	94	Elijah Fears (So.)
OLB	18	MJ Stroud (Sr.)	49	Festus Davies* (Sr.)
ILB	1	BRANDON TYSON (SR.)	15	Holden Trice (Jr.)
ILB	14	Rashon Myles Jr.* (Sr.)	30	CJ Allen Jr. (So.)
CB	12	TRACY HILL JR. (SR.)	20	Jaquari Brown (So.)
CB	38	Noah Mangham* (Sr.)	19	Fabo Chaney (So.)
NB	31	Chance Gamble (Sr.)	24	Phillip Gladney (So.)
SS	23	Jakyri Jones* (Sr.)	29	Devin Collier (So.)
FS	13	Aaron Sears* (Sr.)	32	Jaylen Bentley (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	95	Tripp Bryant (So.)	KR	16	Jamarian Samuel (Sr.)
P	25	Alex Smith (Sr.)	PR	24	Peyton Plott (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER

TYLER KAUFMAN/GETTY IMAGES



CAMERAN BROWN

SCOUTING THE PANTHERS

"They were scary from a roster standpoint last year. They had a guy like [receiver] Ted Hurst who could've played anywhere in the country. Personnel-wise, they were really, really good. What ended up happening when we played them was I don't know that the motivation was there once you got up on them, but it wasn't for a lack of talent and ability. Man to man, they were as good as anybody we played last year. ... They're coming off a rough year, but that quarterback, Cameran Brown, is coming back, and I thought he played well last year. They lost their top receiver [Hurst] and their top two running backs, but they've got a defensive end, Jabriel Rhodes-Nelson, that I think is due for a good year."

—An opposing Sun Belt assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	13	Derrick Avery Jr. (So.)	4	Kyle Washington (So.)
WR	10	DJ Riles (Sr.)	9	Chase Alan-Jackman (Sr.)
WR	19	Rodshaun Dorsey* (Jr.)	17	Isaiah Stone* (Fr.)
LT	76	Jordan Brown* (Sr.)	68	Peter Diaz* (Jr.)
LG	52	DONOVAN FUNSCH (SR.)	71	Aidan Andrews (Fr.)
C	54	TYHLER WILLIAMS (SR.)	75	Marcus Mascoll* (Fr.)
RG	56	DEANDRE DUFFUS (JR.)	72	Kelton Smith Jr.* (Jr.)
RT	77	Connor Jones* (Sr.)	73	Deylin Hasert* (Sr.)
TE	85	Grant Hollier (So.)	35	Avion McBride (Sr.)
QB	8	Cameran Brown (Sr.)	2	Ayden Pereira* (Sr.)
RB	34	Keith Adams Jr.* (Sr.)	5	Lanear McCrary Jr.* (Sr.)

DEFENSE (2)

DE	1	JABRIEL RHODES-NELSON (SR.)	40	Sir Mells (Sr.)
DT	58	Kelze Howard* (Jr.)	99	Mandjou Berte* (Sr.)
DT	92	AJ Vaughns* (Sr.)	91	Tyrese Cathey* (So.)
DE	4	Xavier Esquillen* (Sr.)	95	Richard Kramer (Jr.)
OLB	45	Kelan Butler (So.)	43	Zion Lawson (So.)
ILB	20	Coby Owens (Jr.)	9	Eric Butler Jr.* (Fr.)
ILB	34	Jaydon Hood* (Sr.)	27	Tyler Moore (So.)
CB	26	Jacorey Walker* (Jr.)	11	Toby Bolton* (Fr.)
CB	12	Darius Johnson Jr.* (Sr.)	35	Cade Dutton* (Fr.)
STAR	21	Derrick Maxey III (Jr.)	23	Braylon Alexander* (Sr.)
S	7	DEUCE WALKER (JR.)	8	Deuce Lee* (Sr.)
S	15	Tre Mittman* (Jr.)	35	Kyle Veasley (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K		Balint Vorosmarty (Fr.)	KR	18	D'Ontae Fulton (Fr.)
P	14	Christian Teeter* (Sr.)	PR	18	D'Ontae Fulton (Fr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



GEORGIA STATE PANTHERS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 132 | SUN BELT EAST PREDICTION: 7 | 2025 RECORD: 1-11, 0-8 SBC

OFFENSE After using three starting quarterbacks last season, the Panthers will start the season with Cameran Brown, who threw for 1,296 yards and ran for 271 last year. He was the most effective option when healthy, as evidenced by his 241 passing yards and four TDs against South Alabama. He'll be in competition with Ayden Pereira, a transfer from FCS Merrimack who threw for 1,818 yards and ran for 853 last year.

Georgia State lost record-setting receiver Ted Hurst to the NFL but returns DJ Riles and ascendant tight end Grant Hollier, who didn't get regular playing time until midseason and wound up with 21 catches and four TDs. Clemson transfer Keith Adams Jr. will get a shot at running back, a position that has been high on potential but low on production.

The line must stay healthy after allowing a Sun Belt-low 18 sacks for an offense that ranked 10th in the Sun Belt in total yards. Deandre Duffus and Tyhler Williams are the top returners, and Connor Jones, an import from Michigan, gets high marks.

DEFENSE The poor defense (448.8 ypg, 58 TDs allowed) forced a change in coordinators, with Cam Clark (Duke) and John Haneline (FCS Youngstown State) coming in as co-coordinators. They will try to construct a defense that will create more big plays and turnovers; GSU recovered only three fumbles and intercepted three passes, and the pass rush produced only 18 sacks.

End Jabriel Rhodes-Nelson got a chance to play late in the season and had 41 tackles — seventh-best on the team and the most among returning players. Safety Deuce Walker missed time but returned to collect 33 tackles. Much is expected from Jaydon Hood, a transfer linebacker from Michigan; defensive back Deuce Lee, a top tackler who came in from FCS Monmouth; and safety Tre Mittman, who had 75 tackles at FCS North Carolina A&T.

SPECIALISTS The Panthers hope a new crew will provide more consistency. Christian Teeter will handle the punting, and true freshman Balint Vorosmarty, whose kickoffs were 88.5% touchbacks in high school, should be the kicker. GSU ranked 13th in the Sun Belt in field-goal percentage (43.8%, 134th nationally) and eighth in net punting (37.8 yards).

FINAL ANALYSIS The Panthers have struggled in two seasons under head coach Dell McGee, going 3-9 and 1-11, and a combined 1-15 in the Sun Belt. That's a step back for a program that had been to a bowl game in five of the previous seven years. At least the schedule is easier. Gone are SEC opponents Ole Miss and Vanderbilt, replaced by FCS North Carolina AT&T, Atlanta-area rival Kennesaw State, UCF and Northern Illinois.

2025 RESULTS (1-11, 0-8 SBC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	at Ole Miss	L	7-63	Sept. 5	North Carolina A&T	1. Maxwell Robinson, IOL	★★★
Sept. 6	Memphis	L	16-38	Sept. 12	at Kennesaw State	2. Xavier Butler, RB	★★★
Sept. 13	Murray State	W	37-21	Sept. 19	at UCF	3. Freddie Wilson, DL	★★★
Sept. 20	at Vanderbilt	L	21-70	Sept. 26	Northern Illinois	4. AJ Vaughns, DL	★★★
Oct. 4	James Madison	L	7-14	Oct. 3	Old Dominion	5. Jacorey Walker, S	★★★
Oct. 11	Appalachian State	L	20-41	Oct. 17	at James Madison	6. Timothy Dailey, DL	★★★
Oct. 18	at Georgia Southern	L	24-41	Oct. 24	at Arkansas State	7. Kadorian Benjamin, IOL	★★★
Oct. 23	South Alabama	L	31-38	Oct. 31	Coastal Carolina	8. Kenneth Morgan III, TE	★★★
Nov. 8	at Coastal Carolina	L	27-40	Nov. 7	at Appalachian State	9. Zach Stair, WR	★★★
Nov. 15	Marshall	L	18-30	Nov. 14	Georgia Southern	10. Tyrese Cathey, DL	★★★
Nov. 22	at Troy	L	19-31	Nov. 21	at Marshall		
Nov. 29	at Old Dominion	L	10-27	Nov. 28	Louisiana		

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Dell McGee • Record at School: 5-20 (2+ years) • Career Record: 5-20 (2+ years) • Offensive Coordinator: Hue Jackson • Defensive Coordinators: Cam Clark, John Haneline • Location: Atlanta, Ga. • Stadium: Center Parc Stadium (24,333)



JAMES MADISON DUKES

NATIONAL FORECAST: 82 | SUN BELT EAST PREDICTION: 1 | 2025 RECORD: 12-2, 8-0 SBC

OFFENSE After producing a string of Sun Belt Players of the Year at quarterback, James Madison enters its first season under new head coach Billy Napier with a four-way competition for the starting job. Transfer quarterbacks Arrington Maiden (Memphis) and Davi Belfort (UCF) both played sparingly as freshmen but came to JMU for an opportunity to start. Camden Coleman redshirted last season but has the most starting experience dating back to his time at FCS Richmond, while JC Evans enters his third year in the program. Evans has thrown only 21 passes in his career but was the Boca Raton Bowl MVP in 2024.

Wideout Braeden Wisloski should be a popular target for whoever starts. He's coming off a strong finish to last season, when he scored four touchdowns over the final six games.

DEFENSE Linebacker Gannon Weathersby is back in a bigger role after recording 57 tackles and a sack last season. Safety KJ Flowe is in a similar spot heading into his junior year after coming on strong late last season with a pick-6 against Coastal Carolina.

Amar Thomas is back after a great season at defensive end, and WKU transfer Chukwunedu Okeke, should start, but JMU looked largely to the lower levels to find defensive linemen early in the portal window. Division II transfers such as Kevin Roberts, Jakolbi Wilson and Mason Purham have an opportunity to play a lot up front, while Toledo transfer DJ Kelly might step right into the starting role at corner.

SPECIALISTS Placekicker Morgan Suarez and punter Patrick Rea are back after transferring to JMU last season and immediately earning the starting jobs. Rea punted 48 times for an average of 41 yards with a long of 61 and placed 16 inside the 20-yard line. Suarez didn't have a great start to the season but finished 14-of-19 on field goals and didn't have a miss inside 40 yards.

FINAL ANALYSIS Coming off a College Football Playoff appearance after only four seasons as an FBS program, the Dukes predictably had to reload. Napier replaced new UCLA head coach Bob Chesney, who took several JMU players with him hoping to replicate the national championship formula of fellow former JMU head coach Curt Cignetti at Indiana.

Napier returns to the Sun Belt after a failed stint at Florida, but he previously dominated the conference in four seasons at Louisiana. Much like his successful JMU predecessors, Napier's first recruiting class focused more on standouts from lower levels than Power 4 transfers. There are sure to be some growing pains, but Napier takes over a program where winning the Sun Belt is now the expectation.

2025 RESULTS (12-2, 8-0 SBC)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 30 Weber State W 45-10	Sept. 5 Liberty	1. Kaleb Smith, WR ★★ ★
Sept. 5 at Louisville L 14-28	Sept. 12 Wagner	2. Xavier McDonald, WR ★★ ★
Sept. 20 at Liberty W 31-13	Sept. 19 at San Diego State	3. Kamden Jennings, CB ★★ ★
Sept. 27 Georgia Southern W 35-10	Sept. 26 at Old Dominion	4. Josiah Perry, LB ★★ ★
Oct. 4 at Georgia State W 14-7	Oct. 3 Marshall	5. D'Kwan Thomas, S ★★ ★
Oct. 11 Louisiana W 24-14	Oct. 10 at Georgia Southern	6. Elijah Moss, WR ★★ ★
Oct. 18 Old Dominion W 63-27	Oct. 17 Georgia State	7. Kyle Byrnes II, WR ★★ ★
Oct. 28 at Texas State W 52-20	Oct. 22 at Appalachian State	8. Trace Burney, WR ★★ ★
Nov. 8 at Marshall W 35-23	Oct. 29 Troy	9. Max Roche, TE ★★ ★
Nov. 15 Appalachian State W 58-10	Nov. 5 at Southern Miss	10. Tanner Vibahul, QB ★★ ★
Nov. 22 Washington State W 24-20	Nov. 14 at UConn	
Nov. 29 at Coastal Carolina W 59-10	Nov. 28 Coastal Carolina	
Dec. 5 Troy # W 31-14		
Dec. 20 at Oregon % L 34-51		
#SBC Championship %CFB Playoff First Round		*Per Rivals
TEAM INFORMATION		
Head Coach: Billy Napier • Record at School: First Season		
Career Record: 62-35 (7+ years) • Offensive Coordinator: Cam Aiken		
Defensive Coordinators: Robert Bala, Josh Linam • Location: Harrisonburg, Va.		
Stadium: Bridgeport Stadium (24,877)		



GANNON WEATHERSBY

SCOUTING THE DUKES

"As a university, they've done a good job finding what works for James Madison. They know how to support it. They know how to build it. For all the guys that aren't there, you still have a nucleus of people who only know a championship culture. The floor is going to be higher than other programs going through transitional years. ... I think [new head coach] Billy Napier is a really good coach, and they can get really good players there. It's a great location. The biggest thing with Napier will be proximity to that area. What does he know about it? That transition will be interesting. He did an awesome job at Louisiana and figuring it out there. His reputation as a coach is really strong. I would assume that he'll keep that thing rolling."

— An opposing Sun Belt assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (1)

WR	10	Braeden Wisloski (Sr.)	17	Michael Scott (So.)
WR	3	Corey Scott* (Jr.)	18	Kylan Billiot* (So.)
WR	8	Jeremiah Harrison* (So.)	2	Jayden Mines (Sr.)
LT	77	DJ Fox* (Sr.)		Frankie Tinilau* (Jr.)
LG	72	Kaedin Massey* (So.)	71	Deacon Rawls (So.)
C	60	ZACH GREENBERG (SR.)	70	Noel Portnjagin* (So.)
RG	56	Tyler Brown* (Sr.)	73	Evan Bushong (So.)
RT	53	Daniel Michel* (Jr.)	78	Josh Manecke* (So.)
TE	0	Cole Keller* (Sr.)	82	Thatcher Miller* (Sr.)
QB	5	Arrington Maiden* (So.)	7	Camden Coleman (Jr.)
RB	6	George Pettaway (Sr.)	23	Nick Herman* (So.)

DEFENSE (2)

DL	8	AMAR THOMAS (SR.)	0	Mason Purham* (Jr.)
DL	5	Kevin Roberts* (Jr.)	91	Jakolbi Wilson* (Sr.)
DL	10	Chukwunedu Okeke* (So.)	9	Kei'Trone Simpson* (Sr.)
OLB	26	Jayden Studio (So.)	15	JT Hooten* (So.)
ILB	3	GANNON WEATHERSBY (SR.)	11	Trashon Dye (So.)
ILB	12	Lathan Croley* (Jr.)	15	JT Hooten* (So.)
OLB	2	Nakian Jackson* (Sr.)	11	Trayshon Dye (So.)
CB	6	DJ Kelly* (So.)	36	Milt Ferguson (Jr.)
CB	1	Damir Minkah* (Jr.)	34	Jamal Olford (Fr.)
S	14	KJ Flowe (Jr.)	7	Javis Mynatt* (Sr.)
S	23	Ken Willis (Sr.)	20	Terrence Jones* (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	5	Morgan Suarez (Sr.)	KR	10	Braeden Wisloski (Sr.)
P	11	Patrick Rea (Sr.)	PR	17	Michael Scott (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • 2026 TRANSFER



CARLOS DEL RIO-WILSON

SCOUTING THE THUNDERING HERD

"I think [head coach Tony Gibson] can turn it around. Based on what he walked into, you think you're inheriting a championship roster, and literally, you're starting over from scratch. There wasn't a lot left in the cupboard for him. That being said, he did a good job getting those pieces in place. They're tough, they play hard, they're gritty. They have a confidence about them no matter what their record says. ... They got a running back from [FCS] West Georgia, TJ Lester. I really like him. I watched him in high school, and I've always thought highly of him. I know they signed his little brother there, too. That's kind of how they were able to get him."

—An opposing Sun Belt assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (6)

WR	0	DE'ANDRE TAMAREZ (SR.)	9	Christian Hamilton* (Jr.)
WR	2	ADRIAN NORTON (SR.)	3	Chris Culliver* (Jr.)
WR	20	Owen Sweeney* (So.)	5	Xayvion Turner-Bradshaw (Sr.)
LT	76	TARIQ MONTGOMERY (SR.)	67	Jack Laird (Fr.)
LG	64	Jaquez Joiner* (Fr.)	73	Robby Martin* (So.)
C	56	Andrew Dudley (Fr.)	54	Drake Lanham (Fr.)
RG	70	JALEN SLAPPY (SR.)	57	Logan Greer* (Jr.)
RT	78	Xavier Bausley* (Sr.)	65	Parker Brault (Fr.)
TE	81	TOBY PAYNE (SR.)	85	Tracy Stephens (Jr.)
QB	7	CARLOS DEL RIO-WILSON (SR.)	1	Zion Turner (Sr.)
RB	6	Jo'Shon Barbie (Sr.)	21	TJ Lester* (So.)

DEFENSE (3)

DE	58	Braydin Ward (Jr.)	36	Cole Funderburk* (Fr.)
NT	9	B.J. Carter* (Fr.)	24	Jacarius Clayton (Sr.)
DT	14	Mickel Williams* (Sr.)	98	Terry Nwabuisi-Ezeala* (Fr.)
LB	5	JAVAE GILMORE (SR.)	6	Jalen Marshall (Sr.)
LB	27	Cannon Lewis (So.)	10	Chason Clark (Jr.)
LB	1	Kelvon McBride* (Jr.)	47	EahJay McAdams (Fr.)
CB	2	Charles McCartherens* (Jr.)	8	Eddie Pleasant III* (Jr.)
CB	26	Brayden Hall* (Sr.)	7	TaShawn Jeter (Jr.)
NB	11	JOSH PIERRE-LOUIS (SR.)	4	Philipp Davis (Jr.)
S	17	DAYTONE SMITH (SR.)	3	Terrente Hinton* (Sr.)
S	0	Caleb Clark-Glover (Jr.)	16	Kendall Anderson* (Fr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	41	Jorge Diaz Nicolas* (Fr.)	KR	5	Xayvion Turner-Bradshaw (Sr.)
P	91	Cooper Heimbach (Fr.)	PR	26	Brayden Hall* (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



MARSHALL THUNDERING HERD

NATIONAL FORECAST: 95 | SUN BELT EAST PREDICTION: 3 | 2025 RECORD: 5-7, 3-5 SBC

OFFENSE Last season, first-year head coach Tony Gibson assembled an offense that produced on par with the one that won the conference the previous season. The bones of that group are back, including quarterback Carlos Del Rio-Wilson, who led the Herd in rushing and was an efficient passer in a breakout campaign. Marshall's run-first offense revolves around its quarterback, but it utilizes multiple running backs. Look for Jo'Shon Barbie to assume a larger share of the carries, supplemented by transfer TJ Lester (FCS West Georgia).

Receivers De'Andre Tamarez and Adrian Norton are back, and tight end Toby Payne will start for the third consecutive season. Wideout Owen Sweeney (FCS VMI) also joined the fold after a breakout season. Wide receiver Christian Hamilton and guard Robby Martin are among the contingent that made the move from West Virginia to Marshall.

DEFENSE The Herd had one of the worst defenses in the Sun Belt last season, and P4 teams still picked off several of their top players in the portal. The front was decimated, as three of the top four sack leaders transferred out, and the team's top three tacklers graduated.

Javae Gilmore is the lone starting linebacker returning. Perhaps newcomers Kelvon McBride (NC State) and Mickel Williams (UTSA) can replace the lost pass-rushing production.

But the more pressing concern for new defensive coordinator Brad Lambert, who's back for his third stint at Marshall, is in the secondary. Only a handful of teams allowed more passing yards last season. Safety Daytione Smith and cornerback Josh Pierre-Louis are the main holdovers from a group that routinely allowed explosive plays. The Herd took swings on a slew of transfers, including Charles McCartherens and Eddie Pleasant III from Buffalo. With Boogie Trotter (five interceptions) gone, more playmakers will have to step up on that side of the ball.

SPECIALISTS Transfer Jorge Diaz Nicolas (Virginia) has big shoes to fill after All-MAC placekicker Lorcan Quinn transferred to Alabama. Nicholas has yet to attempt a kick in college, and punter Cooper Heimbach is a true freshman. Cornerback Brayden Hall, a transfer from FCS Central Connecticut State, could handle punt return duties. Kickoff returner Xayvion Turner-Bradshaw is the only established starter of the group.

FINAL ANALYSIS Marshall was in the mix for a bowl game until the season finale despite incredibly difficult circumstances. Now, Gibson has a sturdier foundation to build from and a talented quarterback in Del Rio-Wilson. Taking the next step as a team starts on defense, and that hinges on how well the transfers perform.

2025 RESULTS (5-7, 3-5 SBC)

Aug. 30	at Georgia	L	7-45
Sept. 6	Missouri State	L	20-21
Sept. 13	Eastern Kentucky	W	38-7
Sept. 20	at Middle Tennessee	W	42-28
Sept. 27	at Louisiana (ot)	L	51-54
Oct. 11	Old Dominion	W	48-24
Oct. 18	Texas State (ot)	W	40-37
Oct. 30	at Coastal Carolina	L	27-44
Nov. 8	James Madison	L	23-35
Nov. 15	at Georgia State	W	30-18
Nov. 22	at Appalachian State	L	24-26
Nov. 29	Georgia Southern	L	19-24

2026 SCHEDULE

Sept. 5	at Penn State
Sept. 12	Middle Tennessee
Sept. 19	at Missouri State
Sept. 26	Gardner-Webb
Oct. 3	at James Madison
Oct. 10	Coastal Carolina
Oct. 20	South Alabama
Oct. 31	at Old Dominion
Nov. 7	at Georgia Southern
Nov. 14	Appalachian State
Nov. 21	Georgia State
Nov. 28	at ULM

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1.	Justyn Lyles, OT	★★★
2.	JT Fagan, OT	★★★
3.	Jae'Von White, OT	★★★
4.	Brennan Chambers, WR	★★★
5.	Caden Turner, EDGE	★★★
6.	Jaquez Keyes	★★★
7.	Andre Parker, LB	★★★
8.	Tristan Lester, S	★★★
9.	Jaycee Houston, S	★★★
10.	Zeke Gunn, S	★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Tony Gibson • Record at School: 5-7 (1 year) • Career Record: 5-7 (1 year) • Offensive Coordinator: Rod Smith
Defensive Coordinator: Brad Lambert • Location: Huntington, W.Va. • Stadium: Joan C. Edwards Stadium (30,475)



OLD DOMINION MONARCHS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 94 | SUN BELT EAST PREDICTION: 2 | 2025 RECORD: 10-3, 6-2 SBC

OFFENSE The Monarchs matched their best season in program history in 2025. But the core of that roster — on offense, at least — scattered when the portal opened. Quarterback Colton Joseph, the Sun Belt Offensive Player of the Year, was the most high-profile departure.

The Cure Bowl against South Florida provided a glimpse of what the 2026 team might look like. Head coach Ricky Rahne's teams run the ball at an above-average rate, and that held true in quarterback Quinn Henicle's second career start. He and running back Devin Roche each finished with 100-plus rushing yards in the win over the Bulls. Though ODU added a signal-caller with starting experience in Jaxon Potter (Washington State transfer), it looks like Henicle's job to lose.

Henicle takes the reins of an offense that's breaking in five new starters along the line and trotting out a revamped receiver room. Rahne succeeded in finding diamonds in the rough at receiver last offseason, and he's trying again with transfers JJ Harrell from Holmes (Miss.) Community College and Zion Agnew from Div. II Lenoir-Rhyne.

DEFENSE ODU's defense was lights-out last season. The Monarchs held eight opponents to 10 points or fewer and allowed only 57 points across a six-game winning streak to end the year. With starters back at every level of the defense, that unit should again be among the Sun Belt's best.

Safety and top tackler Mario Easterly returns along with run-stuffing defensive lineman Chris Forbes, both of whom earned All-Sun Belt honors in 2025. Linebacker saw several departures, so the Monarchs brought in transfer Montrell Chapman (Mississippi State) to man the middle.

Few teams created havoc at the rate ODU did in 2025, but some of the most productive players from a unit that finished in the top 10 nationally in sacks and turnovers are no longer there.

SPECIALISTS Nathaniel Eichner took over kicking duties in November and went 7-for-10 on field goals and 19-for-19 on extra points the rest of the way. ODU brought in transfer Andrew Nelms from FAU to compete. Ian Brandt is back at punter, though his average of just under 41 yards was on the low end in the Sun Belt. Roche led the conference in punt return average last season, and he's expanding his duties to kickoff returns, too.

FINAL ANALYSIS Rahne and the Monarchs desperately needed to put it all together in 2025, and they delivered with a historic campaign. ODU would be hard-pressed to repeat that success considering what it lost. Still, the defense provides a high floor, and Henicle could be a reasonable facsimile of Joseph under center. If that's the case, the Monarchs should be bowling — at a minimum — for the second season in a row.

2025 RESULTS (10-3, 6-2 SBC)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 30 at Indiana L 14-27	Sept. 5 Norfolk State	1. Zialis Blackmon, ATH ★★
Sept. 6 NC Central W 54-6	Sept. 12 at Virginia Tech	2. Malachi Harris, DL ★★
Sept. 13 at Virginia Tech W 45-26	Sept. 19 East Carolina	3. Shaq Leaks, S ★★
Sept. 27 Liberty W 21-7	Sept. 26 James Madison	4. TaySean Jones, WR ★★
Oct. 4 Coastal Carolina W 47-7	Oct. 3 at Georgia State	5. Brayden Myovela, WR ★★
Oct. 11 at Marshall L 24-48	Oct. 10 at Appalachian State	6. BJ Bedgood, WR ★★
Oct. 18 at James Madison L 27-63	Oct. 15 Georgia Southern	7. Brooklyn Nace, QB ★★
Oct. 25 Appalachian State W 24-21	Oct. 24 at Louisiana Tech	8. CJ Jackson III, RB ★★
Nov. 1 at ULM W 31-6	Oct. 31 Marshall	9. Jeremiah Deese, S ★★
Nov. 13 Troy W 33-0	Nov. 7 at Coastal Carolina	10. Landon Kehoe, LB ★★
Nov. 22 at Georgia Southern W 45-10	Nov. 21 at UConn	
Nov. 29 Georgia State W 27-10	Nov. 28 Southern Miss	
Dec. 17 vs. South Florida # W 24-10		
#Cure Bowl		
	TEAM INFORMATION	
	Head Coach: Ricky Rahne • Record at School: 30-33 (5 years)	
	Career Record: 30-33 (5 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Kody Cook	
	Defensive Coordinator: Blake Seiler • Location: Norfolk, Va.	
	Stadium: S.B. Ballard Stadium (21,944)	



DEVIN ROCHE

SCOUTING THE MONARCHS

"I hope they've got a regression coming because they were good these last couple years. That quarterback that they lost to Wisconsin [Colton Joseph] was the real deal. Him being gone is the biggest thing. He was that good of a player. ... Their corner, Brandon Crutchfield, and the safety, Lucas Struck, those guys really flashed on tape, and they're back. I remember thinking that when it was time to vote on all-conference. They also signed a linebacker, Montrell Chapman, that they got from Mississippi State. I thought he was a really good player when he was coming out of juco, and when he got in the portal this time, we had already recruited a linebacker, but he would've been a guy that we went after for sure."

—An opposing Sun Belt assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (1)

WR	1	JJ Harrell* (So.)	0	Zion Agnew* (Jr.)
WR	17	Sidney Mbanasor (Sr.)	11	TJ Johnson (Sr.)
WR	7	Kendall Harris* (Jr.)	8	Josh Rodriguez (Fr.)
LT	79	Raykwon Goldthwaite* (Sr.)	68	Martez Curry* (Sr.)
LG	70	Khi'Len Gates* (Jr.)	71	Jack Sheehan (Fr.)
C	50	Brayden Walker* (So.)	66	Mason Thrush* (Jr.)
RG	69	Logan Cox (Jr.)	60	Braden Ellis (Fr.)
RT	75	Demorrison Brown* (So.)	74	Carson Bradley (Jr.)
TE	86	Leon Haughton Jr.* (Sr.)	80	Chris Warren (Fr.)
QB	10	Quinn Henicle (So.)	2	Jaxon Potter* (Jr.)
RB	3	DEVIN ROCHE (JR.)	5	Maurki James (So.)

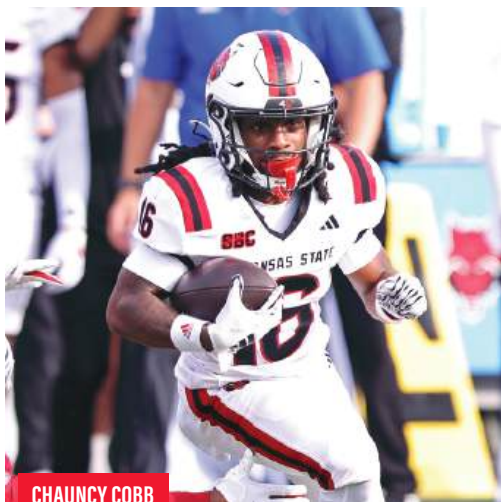
DEFENSE (5)

DE	36	Javen Gibson (Sr.)	40	Hunter Malecki (So.)
DT	9	DEANDRE LYNCH (JR.)	44	Bucci Farmer* (So.)
DE	90	CHRIS FORBES (SO.)	95	Ahmaad Foster (So.)
LB	10	KOA NAOTALA (SR.)	13	Jed Olotu-Judah (So.)
MLB	6	Montrell Chapman* (Sr.)	0	Mario Thompson (Jr.)
LB	18	Jackson Forrest (So.)	24	Dirrick Goodman (Jr.)
CB	1	ZION FRINK (JR.)	23	Jorian Hayes (Jr.)
CB	5	Brandon Crutchfield (Jr.)	8	Greg Johnson* (Jr.)
NB	33	Daevon Iles (Jr.)	26	Justin Watts (So.)
S	3	MARIO EASTERLY (SR.)	20	Jivan Baly* (So.)
S	19	Lucas Struck (Jr.)	7	Ryan Ramey (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	93	Nathaniel Eichner (Sr.)	KR	3	Devin Roche (Jr.)
P	96	Ian Brandt (Jr.)	PR	3	Devin Roche (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



CHAUNCY COBB



ARKANSAS STATE RED WOLVES

NATIONAL FORECAST: 100 | SUN BELT WEST PREDICTION: 2 | 2025 RECORD: 7-6, 5-3 SBC

SCOUTING THE RED WOLVES

"I thought [former quarterback] Jaylen Raynor was really, really good. Thank God that dude isn't in the league anymore. At quarterback, [Texas quarterback transfer] Trey Owens is a really good player that we liked a lot out of high school. I wouldn't be surprised if he factored into that. ... [Running back] Kenyon Clay is back for them, and I thought he was really good last year. They've got a couple of their top receivers back, but I know they lost their best defensive player, Cody Sigler, to Auburn. He was a bada—. And the edge rusher that they got from NC Central, Donquarius Parker, he's gonna be a really good player. I think he can be an all-conference player."

—An opposing Sun Belt assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (7)

WR	3	HUNTER SUMMERS (JR.)	18	Romel Stevens (Fr.)
WR	2	CHAUNCY COBB (JR.)	13	Boski Barrett* (So.)
WR	10	Jaylen Bonelli (Sr.)	0	Nana Burris (Sr.)
LT	71	Tanner Welch* (Jr.)	70	Manasse Itete* (So.)
LG	68	TRISTIAN SMITH (SR.)	77	Gabe Fortson (Jr.)
C	52	MASON MYERS (JR.)	53	Talan Chandler* (So.)
RG	50	WIL SAXTON (SR.)	74	Landry Cannon* (Jr.)
RT	72	Sterling Wiggins* (Jr.)	55	ALERIC WATSON (SR.)
TE	11	Tyler Little (Jr.)	19	Jaden Hamm* (Jr.)
QB	9	Trey Owens* (So.)	6	Ethan Crawford (Jr.)
RB	4	DEVIN SPENCER (JR.)	5	Kenyon Clay (Sr.)

DEFENSE (3)

DE	11	Sultan Badmus* (Jr.)	27	AJ Thomas* (Jr.)
DT	95	Ryan Reese (So.)	44	Sam Hultz* (Sr.)
DT	92	Elias Sherman* (Jr.)	91	Tyeland Coleman* (Jr.)
DE	10	Tony Carter (So.)	14	Donquarius Parker* (Sr.)
LB	16	Joe Drew (So.)	23	Tre Stevens* (Jr.)
LB	22	Nigel Nelson (So.)	9	Kam Moore* (Sr.)
CB	3	Noah Flores* (Jr.)	1	Braden Jackson (Jr.)
CB	0	Dontrae Henderson* (So.)	13	Kyle Williams (So.)
S	6	AG MCGHEE (SR.)	4	Makai Shahid* (Jr.)
S	5	Five Hamilton* (Jr.)	15	BRANDON GREIL (SR.)
S	8	BRANDON BARNES (JR.)	21	Malik McConico (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	34	Clune Van Andel (Sr.)	KR	2	Chauncy Cobb (Jr.)
P	90	Daniel Vuckovic* (Jr.)	PR	10	Jaylen Bonelli (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER

OFFENSE Head coach Butch Jones opted for a new look, hiring Garrett Altman, formerly Vanderbilt's quarterbacks coach, as offensive coordinator. While the tempo is likely to be a little more deliberate, the outcome of a four-man quarterback competition will also determine the approach. Texas transfer Trey Owens is more suited to the pocket at 6-foot-5; Ethan Crawford is a breakaway running threat; and Vanderbilt transfers Drew Dickey and Jérémy St-Hilaire offer a mix of skills.

Running backs Devin Spencer and Kenyon Clay combined for 1,082 rushing yards last year and should find more room behind a transfer-bolstered line. Chauncy Cobb, the Red Wolves' 5-foot-6 slot receiver, caught 73 passes in 2025, while Hunter Summers, a taller target at 6-foot-3, had 44 receptions.

DEFENSE The Red Wolves must rebuild their front after recording 39 sacks last season, tying for the most in the Sun Belt. Six tackles and five ends on the spring roster were first-year transfers. Sophomore Ryan Reese, the only returning defensive tackle, emerged as part of the rotation last season.

Joe Drew, who started the last five games last year as a freshman, switches from nickel safety to linebacker to play alongside Nigel Nelson, who also played heavily as a freshman and finished with 54 tackles. Safety AG McGhee is the top returning tackler (83 total tackles in 2025). Brandon Greil and Brandon Barnes were starters in last year's secondary, and Kennesaw State transfer Five Hamilton is in line for a key role. Arkansas State struggled against the pass in 2025, allowing 245 yards per game.

SPECIALISTS Arkansas State has a trusted kicker in Clune Van Andel, who made a game-winning field goal vs. South Alabama and was 21-of-27 on the year. Cobb, who returned kickoffs for touchdowns against Arkansas and Louisiana, was first-team All-Sun Belt as a return specialist after averaging 26.9 yards per return. Fellow wideout Jaylen Bonelli takes over on punt returns after breaking a 35-yarder in the Xbox Bowl. Daniel Vuckovic, who averaged 42.3 yards per punt last year at Northern Illinois, was the only punter on the spring roster.

FINAL ANALYSIS After losing four of its first five games in 2025, Arkansas State took six of its last eight to finish 7-6 with a victory over Missouri State in the Xbox Bowl. While the Red Wolves have a more manageable schedule with one Power 4 opponent instead of two, they can no longer lean on the two-minute mastery of former quarterback Jaylen Raynor, who engineered six game-winning drives in the past two seasons. Arkansas State's hopes of playing in a fourth consecutive bowl game likely depend on finding a capable successor to Raynor and rebuilding its defensive line.

2025 RESULTS (7-6, 5-3 SBC)

Aug. 30	SE Missouri State	W	42-24
Sept. 6	vs. Arkansas #	L	14-56
Sept. 13	Iowa State	L	16-24
Sept. 20	at Kennesaw State	L	21-28
Sept. 27	at ULM	L	16-28
Oct. 4	Texas State	W	31-30
Oct. 14	at South Alabama	W	15-14
Oct. 25	Georgia Southern	W	34-24
Nov. 1	at Troy	W	23-10
Nov. 8	Southern Miss	L	21-27
Nov. 20	Louisiana	L	30-34
Nov. 29	at Appalachian State	W	30-29
Dec. 18	vs. Missouri State %	W	34-28

#Little Rock, AR %Xbox Bowl

2026 SCHEDULE

Sept. 5	at Memphis
Sept. 12	West Georgia
Sept. 19	at TCU
Sept. 26	Kennesaw State
Oct. 3	at Louisiana
Oct. 8	South Alabama
Oct. 17	at Southern Miss
Oct. 24	Georgia State
Nov. 7	ULM
Nov. 14	at Coastal Carolina
Nov. 21	at Louisiana Tech
Nov. 28	Troy

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1. Tavon Bell, DL	★★★
2. Ezell Jolly, RB	★★★
3. KeAndre Gibson, CB	★★★
4. Brandon Goliday, WR	★★★
5. Paul Risper, CB	★★★
6. Kena Rego, WR	★★★
7. Josh Austin, OT	★★★
8. Dallas Boozer, WR	★★★
9. Tanner Welch, IOL	★★★
10. TJ Spann, DL	★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Butch Jones • Record at School: 26-37 (5 years)
Career Record: 110-91 (15+ years) • Offensive Coordinator: Garrett Altman
Defensive Coordinator: Griff McCarley • Location: Jonesboro, Ark.
Stadium: Centennial Bank Stadium (30,406)



LOUISIANA RAGIN' CAJUNS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 114 | SUN BELT WEST PREDICTION: 4 | 2025 RECORD: 6-7, 5-3 SBC

OFFENSE Quarterback Lunch Winfield came off the bench in late September to lead a wild, come-from-behind win over Marshall and went on to take every snap from that point. A dual-threat type, Winfield typically did more damage with his legs than his arm, but he still has plenty of room to grow as a passer entering his first full year atop the depth chart.

When Lunch isn't calling his own number, carries will be up for grabs following the transfers of running backs Zylan Perry (Cincinnati) and Bill Davis (Virginia Tech), a workmanlike combo who accounted for 3,264 yards and 28 touchdowns over the past two years. The only remotely proven playmaker still in the fold is junior wideout Shelton Sampson Jr., a former LSU signee on breakout watch after emerging as the Cajuns' top receiver in his first year in Lafayette.

Up front, the O-line projects as a strength after an injury-plagued campaign that featured eight different starting combinations. Seven of the 10 linemen who served in that shuffle are back.

DEFENSE Nine of last year's top 10 defenders in terms of snap counts are gone. The one holdover in that group, sophomore cornerback Brent Gordon Jr., looks like a rising star after breaking up 11 passes as a true freshman. The rest of the depth chart is murkier.

There are familiar faces along the front line, where veterans Fitzgerald West Jr., Chase Edwards, Ashley Williams, Lance Williams and Maxie Baudoin IV were all part of the regular rotation. Ditto for safeties Maurion Eleam and Kody Jackson. Linebacker, however, could be in for a full reset. The top three candidates in the spring — Micah Johnson, Conor McPherson and Ethan Veal — are all in their third or fourth year in the program but have played almost exclusively on special teams to date.

SPECIALISTS Kicker Tony Sterner finished 20-of-28 on field-goal attempts in 2025, including 3-of-6 from beyond 50 yards. The new punter, Mason Golding, is the latest in a long line of Aussies to man the position. Ja'Corian Norris took over kick return duties late last year and isn't likely to give them up anytime soon after housing the opening kickoff against rival ULM.

FINAL ANALYSIS Head coach Michael Desormeaux is a south Louisiana lifer running a homegrown program: Only 15 players on the spring roster arrived as transfers, among the fewest in the country. A 10-4 finish in 2024 stands as proof that it's still possible to build a winner the (more or less) old-fashioned way. The baseline, however, has been set by 6-7 records in each of Desormeaux's other three seasons. The challenge in Year 5 is bucking the trend before it becomes the new normal.

2025 RESULTS (6-7, 5-3 SBC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*					
Aug. 30	Rice	L	12-14	Sept. 5	Lamar	1. Jerry Birdlow, TE	★★★				
Sept. 6	McNeese	W	34-10	Sept. 12	at USC	2. Luke Green, CB	★★★				
Sept. 13	at Missouri	L	10-52	Sept. 19	UAB	3. Julius Harper, CB	★★★				
Sept. 20	at Eastern Michigan	L	31-34	Sept. 26	at Charlotte	4. Edrick Williams, CB	★★★				
Sept. 27	Marshall (ot)	W	54-51	Oct. 3	Arkansas State	5. Jayden Reed, S	★★★				
Oct. 11	at James Madison	L	14-24	Oct. 10	at Louisiana Tech	6. Gunnar Goodwin, IOL	★★★				
Oct. 18	Southern Miss	L	10-22	Oct. 17	Troy	7. Patrick Gosslee, LB	★★★				
Oct. 25	at Troy	L	23-35	Oct. 24	at Southern Miss	8. Michael Bowens Jr., OT	★★★				
Nov. 1	at South Alabama	W	31-22	Nov. 7	South Alabama	9. Jai'Vale Fredericks, OT	★★★				
Nov. 8	Texas State	W	42-39	Nov. 12	at ULM	10. Devin Franklin, EDGE	★★★				
Nov. 20	at Arkansas State	W	34-30	Nov. 21	Coastal Carolina						
Nov. 29	ULM (ot)	W	30-27	Nov. 28	at Georgia State						
Dec. 17	vs. Delaware #	L	13-20								
#68 Ventures Bowl				*Per Rivals							
TEAM INFORMATION											
Head Coach: Michael Desormeaux • Record at School: 29-25 (4+ years)											
Career Record: 29-25 (4+ years) • Offensive Coordinator: Tim Leger											
Defensive Coordinator: Jim Salgado • Location: Lafayette, La.											
Stadium: Cajun Field (30,000)											



LUNCH WINFIELD

SCOUTING THE RAGIN' CAJUNS

"I know they returned some of their top players with eligibility left. Pretty good retention for a Group of 6 team. Their quarterback, Lunch Winfield, is back after he took the job about halfway through the year. They started 2-6 and then won four straight to go bowling, and a lot of that was because of him. Really good runner. Their two O-linemen, Kaden Moreau and Cooper Fordham, are really good players on the inside. The leading receiver, Shelton Sampson Jr., who was a 5-star out of LSU, is back. And then another former LSU transfer, defensive tackle Fitzgerald West Jr., got in the portal and then pulled his name out, so I know they're excited about that."

— An opposing Sun Belt assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (8)

WR	6	SHELTON SAMPSON JR. (JR.)	9	KeDarius Wade (Jr.)
WR	17	Landon Strother (So.)	85	Landon Baptiste (Jr.)
WR	8	Jaydon Johnson (Sr.)	2	Rahji Dennis (So.)
LT	57	Zay Alexander (So.)	55	Baylynn Williams (Fr.)
LG	75	KADEN MOREAU (SR.)	61	Jayce Mitchell* (So.)
C	50	COOPER FORDHAM (JR.)	77	Jakoby Isom (So.)
RG	76	MATTHEW BROUSSARD (JR.)	59	Andrew Martinez (Jr.)
RT	71	GEORGE JACKSON (SR.)	52	Ryder Bentley (So.)
TE	88	CADEN JENSEN (JR.)	83	BROCK CHAPPELL (SR.)
QB	7	LUNCH WINFIELD (JR.)	11	Daniel Beale (So.)
RB	22	Anthony Reagan Jr.* (Jr.)	24	Steven Blanco (So.)

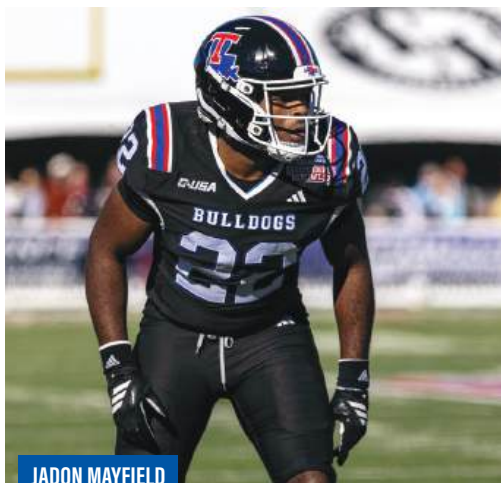
DEFENSE (2)

DE	17	Tito Chikere* (Sr.)	9	Lance Williams (Jr.)
NT	68	FITZGERALD WEST JR. (SR.)	99	Ashton Wright (So.)
DT	41	Chase Edwards (Jr.)	95	Maxie Baudoin IV (Sr.)
ILB	6	Conor McPherson (So.)	44	Jake St. Andre (Sr.)
ILB	3	Micah Johnson (Jr.)	7	Ethan Veal (So.)
OLB	2	Ashley Williams (Jr.)	15	Na'Tori Brown (So.)
CB	11	BRENT GORDON JR. (SO.)	13	Curley Reed III (Jr.)
CB	10	Avery Demery (So.)	23	Jeremiah Moses (Jr.)
NB	21	Maurion Eleam (Sr.)	25	Jayden Gloston (Fr.)
SS	35	Collin Jacob (Sr.)	24	Lake Bates (So.)
FS	8	Kody Jackson (Jr.)	28	Steven Ranel II (Fr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	95	Tony Sterner (Sr.)	KR	15	Ja'Corian Norris (So.)
P	49	Mason Golding (Fr.)	PR	17	Landon Strother (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



JADON MAYFIELD

SCOUTING THE BULLDOGS

"Their top two quarterbacks are back, but Blake Baker is the better passer. Trey Kukuk is a good athlete, gives them some versatility. Kind of a Taysom Hill-type guy. Their leading receiver [tight end Eli Finley], he's a really good player. We were hoping he was gonna get in the portal, but he didn't. Kam Franklin is a safety that I've always liked. And then the DB that they took from Arkansas, Ahkhari Johnson, I think he's gonna be a good addition for them. ... Only bringing in 12 portal guys is crazy, but it all goes back to three or four years ago when [head coach] Sonny Cumbie first got there. They took so many high school guys year in, year out that they've been able to develop and move kids through the program."

— An opposing CUSA assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (4)

WR	86	Talyn Shettron* (Sr.)	11	Jalen Mickens (So.)
WR	47	Jay Wilkerson (Sr.)	83	Luke Watkins (So.)
WR	6	Marcus Calwise Jr.* (Jr.)	15	David Pierro (Sr.)
LT	72	HAYDEN CHRISTMAN (JR.)	76	Cyler Corn (So.)
LG	79	ASHANTI COLE (SR.)	74	Jamon Lee Jr.* (Jr.)
C	60	Roy Brackins III (Jr.)	56	Andrew Richard (So.)
RG	53	Austin Ellis (So.)	66	Will Hutchens (Jr.)
RT	52	Troy Smith III (Jr.)	58	Tye Hylton* (So.)
TE	84	ELI FINLEY (SR.)	87	Brayden Bockler (Jr.)
QB	5	BLAKE BAKER (JR.)	2	Trey Kukuk (Sr.)
RB	23	Jaden Miller* (Jr.)	26	Dylone Brooks (Fr.)

DEFENSE (3)

DL	11	EMMANUEL OGUNS (SR.)	48	Kaden McIver* (Jr.)
NT	97	Justice Williams* (Sr.)	93	Jacob Bradford (So.)
DL	98	Donovan Riemann (Sr.)	99	Judd Rouyea (Jr.)
LB	21	Zheric Hill (So.)	35	Cole Watson (Fr.)
LB	10	KOLBE FIELDS (SR.)	23	Alonzo Jackson Jr. (So.)
LB	22	JADON MAYFIELD (SO.)	33	Jaylon Parnell (Fr.)
CB	2	Amari Butler (Sr.)	17	Demario Bookhart* (So.)
CB	3	Kameron Carter (Sr.)	7	Janard Lockhardt* (Jr.)
NB	0	Jordan McRae (Jr.)	5	Ahkhari Johnson* (Jr.)
SS	4	Kam Franklin (Jr.)	20	Ty Jones* (Sr.)
FS	1	Sam Fongang (Sr.)	13	MJ Moultrie II* (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	38	Kaegan Kent (Fr.)	KR	24	Kenny Thomas (Fr.)
P	30	Reuben Edwards* (Fr.)	PR	6	Marcus Calwise Jr.* (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



LOUISIANA TECH BULLDOGS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 104 | SUN BELT WEST PREDICTION: 3 | 2025 RECORD: 8-5, 5-3 CUSA

OFFENSE Three different quarterbacks saw significant reps in 2025, the majority going to sophomore Blake Baker before a torn ACL ended his season in November. Junior-college transfer Trey Kukuk presided over a three-game winning streak to close the season. Baker went through non-contact drills in the spring, but regardless of the pecking order, there will be a role for Kukuk, who adds a dynamic element as a runner.

Last year's top three running backs all moved on, leaving the position without a player who has played a snap at the NCAA level. The top four wideouts are gone, too, although senior tight end Eli Finley is a proven target underneath. The revamped receiving corps includes 2025 injury casualty Jay Wilkerson; FCS Eastern Kentucky transfer Marcus Calwise Jr.; and Oklahoma State transfer Talyn Shettron, a once-touted recruit.

Up front, left tackle Hayden Christman has logged 24 consecutive starts for an offensive line that allowed the fewest sacks in Conference USA last season.

DEFENSE The Bulldogs feasted on takeaways in 2025, tying for second nationally with 22 interceptions. The bad news: The majority of those picks left with safeties Jakari Foster (NFL), Jacob Fields (TCU) and Michael Richard (Michigan State). The entire starting five in the secondary will be new, with last year's backups vying for reps with an influx of transfers.

There are few concerns at linebacker, where sixth-year vet Kolbe Fields headlines a deep unit. Fields, who came to Ruston from previous stops at South Carolina and LSU, was on his way to living up to his billing as the preseason CUSA Defensive Player of the Year last fall before a leg injury cut his season short. His absence left plenty of reps for freshmen Jadon Mayfield, Alonzo Jackson Jr. and Zheric Hill, who might be difficult to keep off the field as sophomores.

SPECIALISTS Placekickers Drew Henderson and John Hoyet Chance finished just 10-of-18 on field-goal attempts in 2025. Their struggles opened the door late in the year for true freshman Kaegan Kent, who will now compete with Henderson. The new punter, freshman Reuben Edwards, arrived in the spring from Australia. There is no experience in the return game, which means opportunities are there for the taking.

FINAL ANALYSIS After months of uncertainty and legal posturing, Conference USA agreed to a deal in April allowing Louisiana Tech to depart for the Sun Belt for the 2026 season. Thus ends a 13-year run in CUSA that yielded mostly winning conference records but no titles. The move offers the Bulldogs a fresh start in a more competitive league, but matching last season's 8-5 record in their Sun Belt debut figures to be an uphill battle.

2025 RESULTS (8-5, 5-3 CUSA)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*					
Aug. 30	SE Louisiana	W	24-0	Sept. 5	Northwestern State	1. Kenny Thomas, RB	★★★				
Sept. 6	at LSU	L	7-23	Sept. 12	at LSU	2. Nathan Green, S	★★★				
Sept. 13	New Mexico State	W	49-14	Sept. 19	at Baylor	3. Rayshun Hurt, RB	★★★				
Sept. 20	Southern Miss	W	30-20	Oct. 3	Army	4. Demarcus Belton, RB	★★★				
Sept. 27	at UTEP	W	30-11	Oct. 10	Louisiana	5. AJ Tarvin, CB	★★★				
Oct. 9	at Kennesaw State	L	7-35	Oct. 17	at ULM	6. Jeremiah Smith, LB	★★★				
Oct. 21	WKU (ot)	L	27-28	Oct. 24	Old Dominion	7. Damien Richard II, CB	★★★				
Oct. 31	Sam Houston	W	55-14	Oct. 31	at South Alabama	8. Carter Harris, WR	★★★				
Nov. 8	at Delaware	L	24-25	Nov. 7	at Troy	9. Emanuel Collins, S	★★★				
Nov. 15	at Washington State	L	3-28	Nov. 14	Southern Miss	10. Grayson Hardy, S	★★★				
Nov. 22	Liberty (ot)	W	34-28	Nov. 21	Arkansas State						
Nov. 29	at Missouri State	W	42-30	Nov. 28	at Georgia Southern						
Dec. 30	vs. Coastal Carolina # W		23-14								
#Independence Bowl				*Per Rivals							
TEAM INFORMATION											
Head Coach: Sonny Cumbie • Record at School: 19-31 (4 years)											
Career Record: 21-34 (4+ years) • Offensive Coordinator: Nathan Young											
Defensive Coordinator: Luke Olson • Location: Ruston, La.											
Stadium: Joe Aillet Stadium (28,562)											



SOUTH ALABAMA JAGUARS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 115 | SUN BELT WEST PREDICTION: 5 | 2025 RECORD: 4-8, 3-5 SBC

OFFENSE South Alabama's offense took a step back in head coach Major Applewhite's second season at the helm, but the Jaguars will have some vital experience returning.

Quarterback Bishop Davenport (2,072 yards, 12 TDs, six INTs) started all 12 games and finished second in the Sun Belt in completion percentage (68%). Running back Keenan Phillips is USA's leading returning rusher with 607 yards after the departure of All-Sun Belt first-teamer Kentrel Bullock. PJ Martin (326 yards, two TDs) will share the load.

Leading wide receiver Devin Voisin is gone after seven seasons, and Jeremy Scott transferred to TCU, leaving Anthony Eager and Brendan Jenkins as the only two proven pass-catchers. The offensive line returns one starter and welcomes some experienced transfer portal additions.

DEFENSE South Alabama lost a plethora of players from its defensive front to the portal, leaving first-year defensive coordinator Todd Orlando with a rebuild on his hands.

Emmanuel Waller and Stephen Johnson return after being rotational pieces up front last year, while five defensive linemen transferred in, including Mase Lewis (FCS McNeese) and Dylan Chiedo (FCS Furman).

The linebacking corps has to replace some key players, but Tirrell Johnson (54 tackles, a sack, an INT) is back after ranking fifth on the team in tackles, and Caleb Dozier returns from injury.

The secondary lost All-Sun Belt corner Nehemiah Chandler to Florida State. Jayvon Henderson (14 tackles, five PBUs) returns to the other corner spot after playing well opposite Chandler in his first season.

There is a lot of lost production at safety, but Cole Blaylock and Dallas Young saw snaps in all 12 games and will compete for starting jobs.

SPECIALISTS Davis Little appeared in five games at placekicker, mainly playing behind Hamilton DiBoyan. With DiBoyan gone, Little will compete for the full-time job. Aleks Pulkkinen averaged 40.4 yards per punt and landed nine of them inside the 20. Phillips will likely take the kick return job after returning three kicks last season.

FINAL ANALYSIS It's an important Year 3 for Applewhite, who went 4-8 last season after leading South Alabama to a 7-6 finish and bowl win in his first year. Count on the offense to improve. Davenport has the potential to get back to where he was two years ago, and there might be just enough experience back to comprise a good supporting cast. Staff overhauls on defense, coupled with several new players at all three levels, leave a lot more questions than answers, particularly on the defensive line and in the secondary.

2025 RESULTS (4-8, 3-5 SBC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	Morgan State	W	38-21	Sept. 5	SE Louisiana	1. Antwon Thomas, EDGE	★★★★
Sept. 6	Tulane	L	31-33	Sept. 12	at Tulane	2. Tomareo Johnson Jr., S	★★★
Sept. 13	at Auburn	L	15-31	Sept. 19	Ohio	3. Lavonte Cole, RB	★★★
Sept. 20	Coastal Carolina	L	20-38	Sept. 26	at Kentucky	4. Khatori Marion, WR	★★★
Sept. 27	at North Texas	L	22-36	Oct. 3	ULM	5. Brody Jones, WR	★★★
Oct. 4	at Troy (ot)	L	24-31	Oct. 8	at Arkansas State	6. Dominic White, WR	★★★
Oct. 14	Arkansas State	L	14-15	Oct. 20	at Marshall	7. Julius Mathis, TE	★★★
Oct. 23	at Georgia State	W	38-31	Oct. 31	Louisiana Tech	8. Teryn Green, S	★★★
Nov. 1	Louisiana	L	22-31	Nov. 7	at Louisiana	9. Zechariah Hall, LB	★★★
Nov. 15	at ULM	W	26-14	Nov. 14	Troy	10. Tre Webb III, CB	★★★
Nov. 22	Southern Miss	W	42-35	Nov. 21	at Southern Miss		
Nov. 29	at Texas State	L	26-49	Nov. 28	Appalachian State		

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Major Applewhite • Record at School: 11-14 (2 years) • Career Record: 26-25 (4+ years) • Offensive Coordinator: Major Applewhite • Defensive Coordinators: Todd Orland, Jason Washington • Location: Mobile, Ala. • Stadium: Hancock Whitney Stadium (25,450)



BISHOP DAVENPORT

SCOUTING THE JAGUARS

"They flipped most of their roster, but their quarterback [Bishop Davenport] is back, and I thought he was a good player who fit their scheme. It's unfair that he gets compared to [former South Alabama quarterback] Gio Lopeze because he's kind of a similar player. ... I thought the running back that they lost, Kentrel Bullock, was a really good player, but their No. 2 back is back, and they've got some receivers that are really good. Micah Woods, they kind of used him as a gadget guy last year with jet sweeps, and he was their return man. I think he can be a good every-down receiver. Another year in that system might help him. And [wide receiver] Brendan Jenkins only played in a few games last year, but I think he can have a big year for them."

—An opposing Sun Belt assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (2)

WR	11	Anthony Eager (Jr.)	10	Noah Toster (Jr.)
WR	6	Micah Woods (Sr.)	13	Jeremiah Jones-Thomas (So.)
WR	12	Brendan Jenkins (Sr.)	83	Jerrian Graham (So.)
LT	55	Khayree Lee Jr.* (So.)	68	Reese Osei-Wusu (Jr.)
LG	69	Kenton Jerido (Sr.)	66	Devin White (Fr.)
C	60	Devon Waller* (Jr.)	78	Aydan Newell (Fr.)
RG	57	Shalik Hubbard* (Sr.)	76	Logan Joellenbeck (So.)
RT	72	ETHAN HUBBARD (JR.)	77	Kearius Bivens (Fr.)
TE	19	Rod Gibbs (Sr.)	82	Everett Hunter* (Sr.)
QB	4	BISHOP DAVENPORT (SR.)	7	Jared Hollins (So.)
RB	21	Keenan Phillips (Jr.)	0	PJ Martin (Jr.)

DEFENSE (3)

DE	88	Mase Lewis* (Sr.)	41	Tyler Carter (So.)
NT	97	Stephen Johnson (Jr.)	98	Tre Brown (Jr.)
DT	9	EMMANUEL WALLER (SR.)	51	Jordan May (Jr.)
EDGE	42	Dylan Chiedo* (Jr.)	90	E'Mauri Smiley (So.)
LB	20	TIRRELL JOHNSON (SR.)	26	Parker Shattuck (Jr.)
LB	16	Seidrión Langston* (Sr.)	22	Caleb Dozier (So.)
CB	2	JAYVON HENDERSON (SR.)	24	Damyron Darby (Jr.)
CB	16	Jaylen Moson* (Jr.)	15	Tre Webb III* (Jr.)
NB	17	Dallas Young (Jr.)	34	Bradley Thomas (Sr.)
S	12	Anthony Brown (Sr.)	11	DJ Moore* (Sr.)
S	14	Cole Blaylock (Jr.)	4	Kohl Bradley (Fr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	35	Davis Little (So.)	KR	21	Keenan Phillips (Jr.)
P	40	Aleks Pulkkinen (Sr.)	PR	6	Micah Woods (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



LANDRY LYDDY

SCOUTING THE GOLDEN EAGLES

"You get a little bit of continuity with [new head coach] Blake Anderson having already been on staff. His reputation, and his familiarity with the conference. They're in a fertile recruiting footprint, so there won't be any challenges in terms of having talent. They were a game away from playing for a Sun Belt championship, and you can at least still use that momentum in the return and the respectability as a rallying cry going into this season. ... They basically flipped over a new roster. One guy that they brought in, [defensive lineman] Kameron Cyprien, he's a juco guy they got, and I think he's gonna be an all-conference player."

—An opposing Sun Belt assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (1)

WR	8	A.J. Little* (Jr.)	13	Grant Page (Sr.)
WR	11	Davis Dalton (Sr.)	23	Trey Horne (Jr.)
WR	7	Kaden Saunders* (Jr.)	1	Mario Sanders II* (Sr.)
LT	70	Braden Cain* (Jr.)	63	Da'Jay'Quwan Jackson-Payne* (Jr.)
LG	74	Luke Rogers (Jr.)	53	Toby Mealer* (Fr.)
C	67	BRODERICK ROMAN (SR.)	73	Hayden Breal (Fr.)
RG	77	Chase Malamala (So.)	75	Casey Jean-Baptiste* (Jr.)
RT	78	Christian Young* (Sr.)		Dante Devine* (Jr.)
TE	88	Javery Mayberry* (So.)	81	Preston Kilgore* (Jr.)
QB	14	Ethan Hampton* (Sr.)	18	Landry Lyddy (Sr.)
RB	2	Robert Briggs (Sr.)	26	Brandon Hood* (So.)

DEFENSE (0)

DE	11	A'mari Wilson* (Jr.)	41	Will Smith* (So.)
NT	52	Xavier McIver* (Sr.)	91	Jackson Banks* (Jr.)
DT	95	Josh Johnson* (Sr.)	55	Nasim Cairo* (Sr.)
DE	90	Jeffery Rush* (So.)	7	Kameron Cyprien* (Jr.)
LB	13	Mathis Haygood (Jr.)	45	Teyondre Coleman* (Jr.)
LB	6	Andrew Martin* (Sr.)	42	Melvin Spriggs* (Jr.)
CB	23	Hiroshi Carr* (Jr.)	8	Ishmael Ibraheem (Sr.)
CB	1	Champ Lewis* (Sr.)	27	Kelby Hampton* (So.)
NB	15	Jyaire Brown* (Sr.)	18	MaLik Caswell (So.)
SS	25	Landon Sylvie* (Jr.)	12	Laquan Robinson* (Sr.)
FS	26	Baron Taylor* (Jr.)	22	Kobi Albert* (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	40	Creighton Wilbanks (So.)	KR	8	A.J. Little* (Jr.)
P	36	Dusty Zimmer* (Fr.)	PR	8	A.J. Little* (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



SOUTHERN MISS GOLDEN EAGLES

NATIONAL FORECAST: 123 | SUN BELT WEST PREDICTION: 6 | 2025 RECORD: 7-6, 5-3 SBC

OFFENSE Southern Miss returns exactly one starter: seventh-year offensive lineman Broderick Roman, who took every meaningful snap at center in 2025 in his first year on campus. Otherwise, "we're starting from scratch on 99% of this roster," says new head coach Blake Anderson, whose promotion from offensive coordinator last December coincided with a mass exodus via graduation and the portal.

At quarterback, a pair of new arrivals — senior transfer Ethan Hampton and true freshman Hugh Price — split spring reps with last year's backups, Landry Lyddy and John White. If experience counts for anything, the edge goes to Hampton, a sixth-year vet with 14 FBS starts under his belt at Northern Illinois. But Hampton barely saw the field in 2025 at Illinois, and the 6-foot-5 Price is looming, literally and figuratively.

The biggest wild card among the new arrivals is Penn State transfer receiver Kaden Saunders, a former blue-chip recruit more than two years removed from his last live rep due to a nagging foot injury. At full speed, he could be the most dynamic presence in the Southern Miss attack.

DEFENSE The defense under first-year coordinator Joe Bolden will consist almost entirely of transfers, none of whom has logged more than 500 snaps at the FBS level. There is some untapped talent on hand, with once-touted prospects who began their careers at Auburn (DB Laquan Robinson), Ole Miss (DE Jeffery Rush), Ohio State (DB Jyaire Brown), TCU (CB Champ Lewis), Texas (CB Ishmael Ibraheem) and Texas A&M (DB Jordan Pride).

They'll be competing for reps with an influx from the FCS and junior-college ranks, among them 6-foot-6 edge rusher A'mari Wilson (Campbell), seasoned linebacker Andrew Martin (Stetson) and lanky cornerback Hiroshi Carr (Morgan State).

SPECIALISTS Placekickers Creighton Wilbanks and Reed Harradine return, but the pair was inconsistent, connecting on just 4-of-10 field-goal attempts from beyond 40 yards. The new punter, Dusty Zimmer, is a strapping Australian by way of Washington. FCS Chattanooga transfer A.J. Little is most likely to succeed in the return game after housing a pair of punt returns in 2025 for the Mocs.

FINAL ANALYSIS Few traces remain of last year's team, which ran out of gas in November after starting 5-0 in Sun Belt play. Anderson, who led his teams to nine bowl games in 10 seasons as head coach at Arkansas State (2014-20) and Utah State (2021-23), is no stranger to winning under less-than-ideal circumstances. But trotting out what amounts to a brand-new team in Year 1 is a new one even for him.

2025 RESULTS (7-6, 5-3 SBC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*					
Aug. 30	Mississippi State	L	17-34	Sept. 5	Alcorn State	1. Chauncey Davis Jr., CB	★★★				
Sept. 6	Jackson State	W	38-20	Sept. 12	at Auburn	2. Caleb Triplett, LB	★★★				
Sept. 13	Appalachian State	W	38-22	Sept. 19	UConn	3. David Aboya, WR	★★★				
Sept. 20	at Louisiana Tech	L	20-30	Sept. 26	at Tulane	4. Elijiah Singleton, WR	★★★				
Sept. 27	Jacksonville State	W	42-25	Oct. 6	at Troy	5. Broderick Peters, TE	★★★				
Oct. 9	at Georgia Southern	W	38-35	Oct. 17	Arkansas State	6. Ari Slocum, IOL	★★★				
Oct. 18	at Louisiana	W	22-10	Oct. 24	Louisiana	7. Hugh Price, QB	★★★				
Oct. 25	ULM	W	49-21	Oct. 31	at ULM	8. Talik Parkman, DL	★★★				
Nov. 8	at Arkansas State	W	27-21	Nov. 5	James Madison	9. Teyondre Coleman, LB	★★★				
Nov. 15	Texas State	L	14-41	Nov. 14	at Louisiana Tech	10. Dante Devine, IOL	★★★				
Nov. 22	at South Alabama	L	35-42	Nov. 21	South Alabama						
Nov. 29	Troy	L	18-28	Nov. 28	at Old Dominion						
Dec. 23	vs. WKU #	L	16-27								
#New Orleans Bowl				*Per Rivals							
TEAM INFORMATION											
Head Coach: Blake Anderson • Record at School: 0-1 (1 year)											
Career Record: 0-1 (1 year) • Offensive Coordinator: Kyle Cefalo											
Defensive Coordinator: Joe Bolden • Location: Hattiesburg, Miss.											
Stadium: M.M. Roberts Stadium (36,000)											



TROY TROJANS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 81 | SUN BELT WEST PREDICTION: 1 | 2025 RECORD: 8-6, 6-2 SBC

OFFENSE When he's healthy, sixth-year quarterback Will "Goose" Crowder is a steady hand with all-conference potential. The problem is keeping him upright: Crowder has missed 14 games over the past two seasons to assorted injuries. His understudy, fellow senior Tucker Kilcrease, took the majority of snaps in 2025 while presiding over a 5-2 record as a starter.

Troy needs more from the surrounding cast after finishing dead last in the Sun Belt in both total offense and yards per play. A new coordinator, Adam Austin, arrived in January from the highest-scoring team in the FCS, Tarleton State. So did an influx of skill talent from the junior-college ranks, headlined by junior-college All-America running back Gavin Griffin and former Ole Miss signee Noreel White, a wide receiver.

Up front, the Trojans welcome back left tackle Elijah Prather, whose sophomore campaign ended at midseason due to injury.

DEFENSE Nearly the entire starting lineup moved on, but there are familiar faces. Juco product Donnie Smith broke out in 2025, earning a first-team All-Sun Belt nod despite being limited to a part-time role in his first year on campus. In Year 2, Smith is entrenched at "Bandit," earning praise from head coach Gerad Parker in the spring for his emergence as a vocal leader. Former walk-on Justin Powe is entering his third year as a starter at safety. Seniors Kam Curry, Luke Hodge, TJ Thompson, Jordan Perry and Jabari Strait are all due for promotions to more prominent roles.

Newcomers include two SEC refugees via Arkansas (DE Kavion Henderson) and Tennessee (S Marcus Goree Jr.), both of whom will compete for reps, as well as a pair of injury-plagued transfers from Boston College, DT Ty Clemons and LB Bryce Steele, looking to go out on a high note.

SPECIALISTS Punter Evan Crenshaw earned Sun Belt Special Teams Player of the Year honors as a junior after dropping 29 punts inside opponents' 20-yard lines, most in the nation. Kicker is less settled, with four candidates who have yet to attempt a field goal at the D-I level. The competition at the return spots is similarly wide open.

FINAL ANALYSIS Parker's predecessor, Jon Sumrall, set a lofty bar by winning back-to-back conference titles in 2022 and '23. Nobody was about to confuse the 2025 Trojans with those teams, but they did take a big step in the right direction, finishing atop the Sun Belt West. For all its losses, the defense under third-year coordinator Dontae Wright can still be counted on to hold up its end of the bargain. If the revamped offense follows suit — a big if, largely hinging on Crowder's health and consistency — a fourth trip to the SBC Championship Game in five years is within reach.

2025 RESULTS (8-6, 6-2 SBC)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 30 Nicholls W 38-20	Sept. 5 Sam Houston	1. Dontaye Bush, EDGE ***
Sept. 6 at Clemson L 16-27	Sept. 12 Alabama State	2. Jermaine McCree, CB ***
Sept. 13 Memphis L 7-28	Sept. 19 at Missouri	3. Jaxon Penn, CB ***
Sept. 20 at Buffalo W 21-17	Sept. 26 at Utah State	4. Keivay Foster, S ***
Oct. 4 South Alabama (ot) W 31-24	Oct. 3 Southern Miss	5. Noreel White, WR ***
Oct. 11 at Texas State (ot) W 48-41	Oct. 17 at Louisiana	6. Lonnie Smith, EDGE ***
Oct. 18 at ULM W 37-14	Oct. 24 ULM	7. Hayden Jackson, WR ***
Oct. 25 Louisiana W 35-23	Oct. 29 at James Madison	8. Nick Hampton, TE ***
Nov. 1 Arkansas State L 10-23	Nov. 7 Louisiana Tech	9. Corey Dudley Jr., OT ***
Nov. 13 at Old Dominion L 0-33	Nov. 14 at South Alabama	10. Jeremiah Roux, ATH ***
Nov. 22 Georgia State W 31-19	Nov. 21 Georgia Southern	
Nov. 29 at Southern Miss W 28-18	Nov. 28 at Arkansas State	
Dec. 5 at James Madison # L 14-31		
Dec. 16 vs. Jacksonville St. % L 13-17		
#SBC Championship %Salute to Veterans Bowl		

TEAM INFORMATION
Head Coach: Gerad Parker • Record at School: 12-14 (2 years)
Career Record: 12-20 (2+ years) • Offensive Coordinator: Adam Austin
Defensive Coordinator: Dontae Wright • Location: Troy, Ala.
Stadium: Veterans Memorial Stadium (30,470)



GOOSE CROWDER

SCOUTING THE TROJANS

"I would imagine they've won big with three different coaches recently because of the funding of the program and the location where they can recruit. ... They lost a lot of production, but they did return some key pieces. At quarterback, the two guys that started, Tucker Kilcrease and Goose Crowder, are both back. We went into our game against Kilcrease thinking he'd be more of a game manager, but he actually made some plays and went out and won it for them. I don't know how they're gonna play it with those guys back. ... I thought [safety] Justin Powe was a good player and he's back. Then they have a receiver, Mojo Dortch, who had a season-ending injury last year, but I think he's a guy to watch for a breakout year."

—An opposing Sun Belt assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (4)

WR	5	Mojo Dortch (Sr.)	7	Kristian Tate (Sr.)
WR	4	Noreel White* (So.)	81	Jah'Marren Jackson (Fr.)
WR	15	TJ Lott* (Jr.)	2	Jywon Boyd (So.)
LT	58	ELIJAH PRATHER (JR.)	77	Darion Rivers* (Jr.)
LG	50	Luke Petit* (Sr.)	72	Patrick Screws Jr. (Jr.)
C	65	Tyler Cappi (Sr.)	73	Tyler Bell (Jr.)
RG	55	Jordan Jones* (Sr.)	71	Antwone Breland* (So.)
RT	74	TRA'JON TOWNSEND (JR.)	54	CALEB ASH (SO.)
TE	88	Jackson Worley (Jr.)		JaCorey Whitted* (So.)
QB	9	GOOSE CROWDER (SR.)	10	Tucker Kilcrease (Sr.)
RB	1	Jordan Lovett (Jr.)	0	Gavin Griffin* (Jr.)

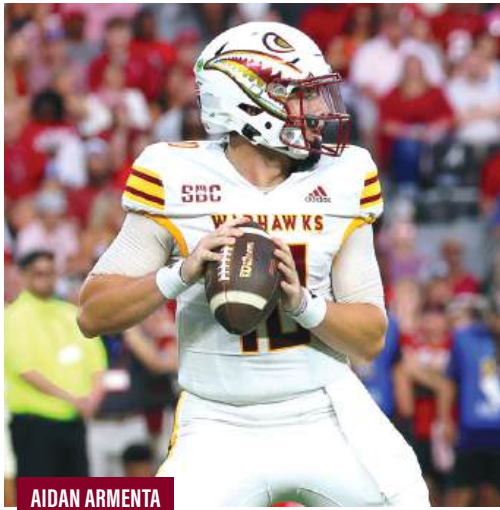
DEFENSE (1)

DE	69	Jermaine Paramore (So.)	25	Kavion Henderson* (So.)
DT	0	Kam Curry (Sr.)	93	RaKeem Davis* (Jr.)
DT	11	Ty Clemons* (Sr.)	95	Miquon Merriweather* (Jr.)
BANDIT	22	Donnie Smith (Sr.)	5	Lonnie Smith* (Jr.)
LB	44	Luke Hodge (Sr.)	15	Keno Jones* (Sr.)
LB	2	Bryce Steele* (Sr.)	4	TJ Thompson (Sr.)
CB	1	Jabari Strait (Sr.)	12	Shemar Welch (So.)
CB	14	Jonathan Pennix* (Jr.)	17	Marlin Odom (So.)
SPEAR	18	Jordan Perry (Sr.)	3	Doug Nelson* (Jr.)
SS	6	JUSTIN POWE (SR.)	8	Marcus Goree Jr.* (So.)
FS	29	Joe Lott (So.)	10	Knai Cook* (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	38	Hayden Wolfe* (Jr.)	KR	4	Noreel White* (So.)
P	28	Evan Crenshaw (Sr.)	PR	4	Noreel White* (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



AIDAN ARMENTA

SCOUTING THE WARHAWKS

"That place is a tough place to win, man. We don't have a ton of funding right now, and I know that they're even worse off than we are. It's difficult, and [head coach] Bryant Vincent has tried to make something out of it. ... This year, it's tough to know what they're gonna look like, but it feels like the same shape that it's been in the past couple years. They signed more than 20 juco guys and then another 20 portal guys. It's a new roster. [Quarterback] Aiden Armenta is back. He manages the game. He can run a little bit, and he lets them do some different things. They lost their running back, Bam McReynolds, to UAB, and I thought he was a really good player."

— An opposing Sun Belt assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	7	Nic Trujillo (Jr.)	5	Brandon Buckhaultner (Sr.)
WR	88	Marcellus Jackson* (So.)	9	LT Robinson* (Jr.)
WR	4	JP COULTER (SR.)	6	Damarcco Blanton* (So.)
LT	60	David Applewhite (Jr.)	69	Bright Fagbamiye* (Sr.)
LG	61	Kaliem Crowell (Sr.)	54	Nate Green (So.)
C	72	Sean Dugery* (Sr.)	64	Drew Hutchinson (Sr.)
RG	66	Nolan Anderson* (Jr.)	62	Adameon Botley (Sr.)
RT	67	AJ VINSON (SR.)	68	Quentis Griffin Jr. (Sr.)
TE	8	Bryce Anderson* (Jr.)	89	Cade Callahan* (Jr.)
QB	10	AIDAN ARMENTA (JR.)	9	Landon Graves (Jr.)
RB	20	Donald Chaney Jr.* (Sr.)	1	Derrick Jameson* (Jr.)

DEFENSE (2)

DE	92	James Smith (Sr.)	44	CJ Wilson Jr.* (Sr.)
DT	45	CLIFF MOSLEY (SR.)	35	Ethan Bailey (So.)
DT	95	Levontae Jacobs (Sr.)	90	Zyan Tremont* (Jr.)
EDGE	9	Jaeden Calender (Jr.)	4	Derek Omoregie (Sr.)
OLB	1	Jabari Tiller (Sr.)	19	Le'Kell McGowan* (Jr.)
MLB	10	Rickey Banks* (Jr.)	22	Fred Clark (Fr.)
OLB	3	NOAH FLEMMINGS (SR.)	30	Marcus Ross (Sr.)
CB	5	Zy Jackson (Sr.)	20	Jordyn Williams (So.)
CB	13	Armoni Rue* (Sr.)	25	Navarion Benson (Sr.)
S	21	Lynard Harris (Jr.)	28	Larell Howling* (So.)
S	2	Korian Wilson (Sr.)	8	Carl Fauntroy (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	99	Max Larson (Sr.)	KR	4	JP Coulter (Sr.)
P	47	Makenzie Ryan (Jr.)	PR	4	JP Coulter (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



ULM WARHAWKS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 131 | SUN BELT WEST PREDICTION: 7 | 2025 RECORD: 3-9, 1-7 SBC

OFFENSE ULM ranked near the bottom of the Sun Belt in both total offense and scoring offense in head coach Bryant Vincent's second season, averaging only 323.5 yards and 16.6 points per game during a 3-9 campaign that represented a step back from a five-win season in 2024. Returning starting quarterback Aidan Armenta (1,628 passing yards, 12 TDs, eight INTs) will try to improve a passing game that finished dead last in the league in yards per game (160.4). Nic Trujillo (23 receptions, 368 yards, four TDs) returns at wide receiver, but much of the receiving corps is largely unproven. Memphis transfer tight end Bryce Anderson could help with the pass-catching duties.

ULM's strength was running the ball, but the Warhawks must replace leading rusher Zach Palmer-Smith. Former Louisville and Miami (Fla.) running back Donald Chaney Jr. was one of a few transfer portal additions to the Warhawks' backfield.

Returning starting tackle AJ Vinson will anchor an offensive line that has to replace four starters.

DEFENSE ULM improved defensively last season, finishing sixth in the Sun Belt in total defense (384.8 ypg). The Warhawks were more balanced than they had been the previous season, allowing just 162.6 rushing yards and 222.3 passing yards per game. But they do have some pieces to replace on the defensive line and in the secondary.

The linebacker position has a few returning players who were part of the rotation last season, including Noah Flemmings and Marcus Ross. There are four new faces in the secondary, including corner Armoni Rue, a former junior-college All-American who appeared in five games for UTEP last season.

SPECIALISTS ULM might have a kicking competition on its hands. Max Larson is back after missing 2025 with an injury. Jacob Chambless returns for his second season, while Abram Murray transferred in from Cal. Makenzie Ryan will hold down punting duties after averaging 38.8 yards per punt as a sophomore.

FINAL ANALYSIS Vincent's first season (2024) was promising, as ULM started 5-1 before losing its last six. Last season was similar, with the Warhawks unable to capitalize on a 3-1 start, losing their last eight and going 1-7 in the Sun Belt. Vincent made several staff changes in the offseason, particularly on offense, adding offensive coordinator Jesse Montalto in addition to the portal pickups at receiver to try to jumpstart the passing game. If the defense can continue to build on its 2025 gains, ULM could get back in the bowl conversation.

2025 RESULTS (3-9, 1-7 SBC)

Aug. 28	Saint Francis (Pa.)	W	29-0
Sept. 6	at Alabama	L	0-73
Sept. 20	at UTEP	W	31-25
Sept. 27	Arkansas State	W	28-16
Oct. 4	at Northwestern	L	7-42
Oct. 11	at Coastal Carolina	L	8-23
Oct. 18	Troy	L	14-37
Oct. 25	at Southern Miss	L	21-49
Nov. 1	Old Dominion	L	6-31
Nov. 15	South Alabama	L	14-26
Nov. 22	at Texas State	L	14-31
Nov. 29	at Louisiana (ot)	L	27-30

2026 SCHEDULE

Sept. 5	at Mississippi State
Sept. 12	at UAB
Sept. 19	SE Louisiana
Sept. 26	Florida Atlantic
Oct. 3	at South Alabama
Oct. 17	Louisiana Tech
Oct. 24	at Troy
Oct. 31	Southern Miss
Nov. 7	at Arkansas State
Nov. 12	Louisiana
Nov. 21	at Appalachian State
Nov. 28	Marshall

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1. Gavin Howard, ATH	★★★★
2. Jeremyah Green, IOL	★★★★
3. Marcellus Jackson, WR	★★★★
4. Van Martinez, IOL	★★★★
5. DJ Jester, S	★★★★
6. Freddie Gavin Jr., IOL	★★★★
7. Jonathan Crain, CB	★★★★
8. Mike Williams, WR	★★★★
9. Edarius Green, IOL	★★★★
10. Dalen Huston, WR	★★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Bryant Vincent • Record at School: 8-16 (2 years) • Career Record: 15-22 (3 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Jesse Montalto • Defensive Coordinator: Troy Reffett • Location: Monroe, La. • Stadium: Malone Stadium (27,617)